

Global Progress Report on Sustainable Development Goal 16

Indicators on Peaceful, Just and Inclusive Societies



SDG 16

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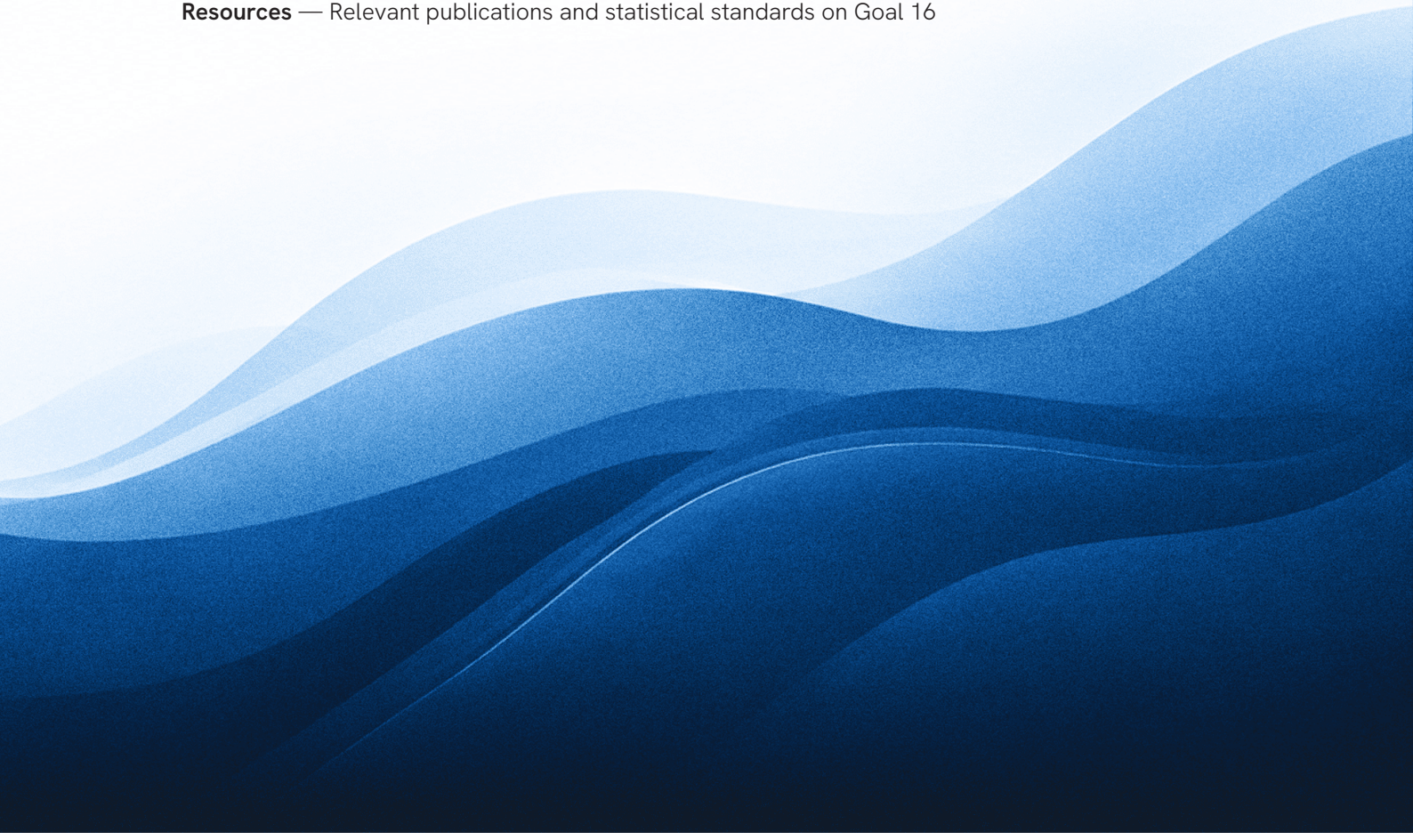


Justice chapter



Inclusion chapter

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Foreword

More than a decade after Member States adopted the 2030 Agenda, the conditions for sustainable development have changed profoundly. Humanity possesses greater technological, scientific and economic capabilities than at any point in history. Yet growing insecurity, deepening polarization and declining trust, alongside violent conflicts, economic uncertainty and geopolitical fragmentation, are making hard-won development gains increasingly fragile. In this context, the challenge of our time is not only identifying solutions but ensuring that institutions are capable and resilient enough to turn those solutions into life-changing results.

This report examines global progress towards Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 16. The evidence presented here reminds us that Goal 16 is not simply one of 17 goals. Peace, justice and inclusive institutions are the foundations on which progress across the entire 2030 Agenda depends.

Drawing on the latest global evidence, the report presents a mixed picture of progress. Important gains have been achieved in several areas, from expanding legal identity and women's representation in public institutions to the establishment of independent human rights institutions and access to information laws. Yet progress remains uneven. Large shares of the population continue to experience violence and discrimination, barriers to justice persist, and progress across several indicators has stalled or remains too slow to meet the ambitions of the 2030 Agenda.

The findings of this report point to a clear lesson: lasting progress depends on sustained political commitment, long-term investment, strong partnerships and institutions that earn and maintain public trust. They also reinforce the importance of prevention. Investing early in children, women and those at risk of being left behind, while strengthening justice systems, human rights protection, accountable governance, public integrity, and effective public services is far less costly - and far more effective - than responding after violence, conflict, corruption or exclusion have already taken hold.

As we enter the final years of the 2030 Agenda, the message is both urgent and hopeful. Progress is possible. But it does not happen by itself. It requires deliberate choices and sustained effort. The vision of the SDGs is clear: a world where peace, justice and strong institutions are not privileges enjoyed by some. They are the foundations of a future that works for all.



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1. Peace

Peace is at the heart of SDG 16 and a fundamental condition for sustainable development. Peace is often understood as the absence of war. Yet peace is experienced much more broadly through people's everyday lives, such as whether children grow up free from violence, people feel safe in their communities, and adults can live and participate in society without experiencing or fearing violence. No single indicator can capture such a complex reality. Instead, the indicators of Goal 16 measure the different ways that violence and insecurity affect people, providing a multidimensional picture of peace.

At its most visible, the lack of peace appears as lives lost. Armed conflicts and intentional homicides are among the most devastating manifestations of violence. In 2025, the human toll remains staggering. A civilian is killed every 14 minutes, and one in five recorded deaths in conflict is a child. Beyond conflict zones, intentional homicide continues to claim more than 400,000 lives each year, despite a 13 per cent decline in the global homicide rate over the past decade.

Peace is not measured only by lives lost. The absence of peace through non-lethal violence can begin early in life and continue throughout adulthood, leaving a lasting impact on individuals, families, and communities. For example, two in three children experience violent punishment by caregivers at home. One in eight girls

and women alive today experienced rape or sexual assault during childhood, while children account for 37 per cent of all detected victims of trafficking.

For many, violence does not end with childhood. Physical, sexual, or psychological violence among adults not only harms individuals but also affects entire communities by reducing social participation, suppressing economic activity, and eroding trust. And even when people are not direct victims of violence, fear shapes their daily lives. Today, one in three people globally report feeling unsafe walking alone at night where they live. When people do not feel safe in their own neighbourhoods, they limit their movements, reduce civic engagement, and place less trust in the institutions responsible for protecting them.

The ability of institutions to protect people is also reflected in how they safeguard those who defend the rights of others. Human rights defenders, journalists and trade unionists play a vital role in exposing abuses and holding institutions accountable, yet, globally one defender is killed or forcibly disappeared every 10 hours.

Taken together, these indicators show that peace depends not only on the absence of violence but also on the strength of institutions to prevent conflict, protect fundamental rights, and ensure accountability.

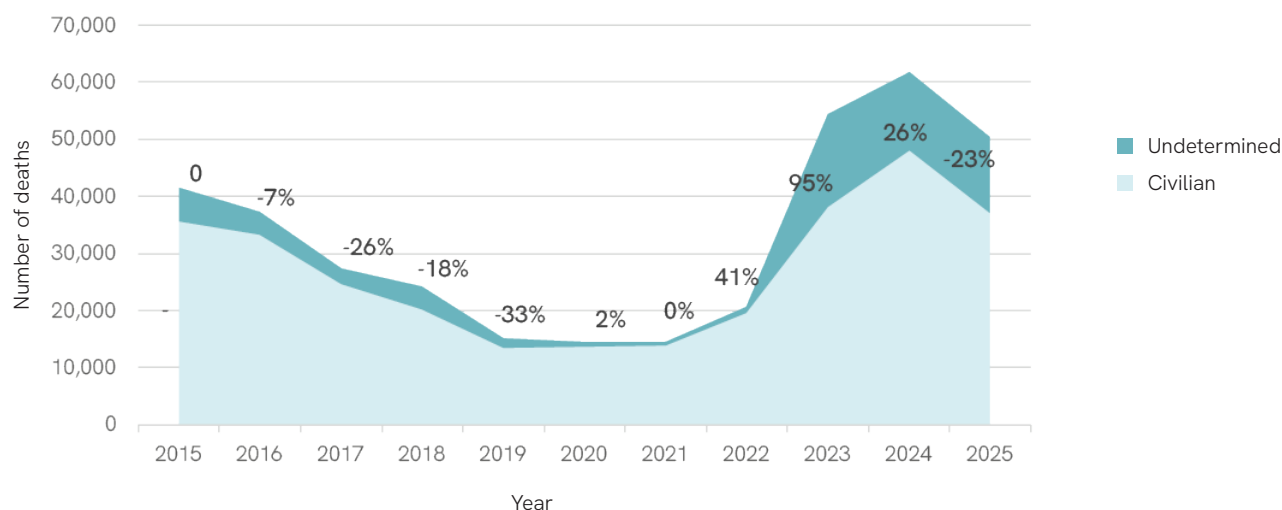
A civilian dies every 14 minutes in armed conflict

Across the 20 situations of armed conflict for which UN Human Rights documented conflict-related deaths,¹ at least 37,163 civilian deaths were documented in 2025, down from 48,011 in 2024, the highest number recorded since the adoption of the 2030 Agenda.² After three consecutive years of rising conflict-related deaths, this represents a 23 per cent decline in documented civilian deaths. Nonetheless, the overall situation remains alarming. A civilian was killed every 14 minutes, showing the devastating and persistent human cost of armed conflict.

Northern Africa and Western Asia accounted for 65 per cent of all documented civilian deaths, while Sub-Saharan Africa accounted for 24 per cent. While a downward trend was recorded in most covered conflicts, hostilities in Sudan and the Democratic Republic of the Congo resulted in significant increases in civilian fatalities, demonstrating that progress is uneven across conflict settings.

Documentation of conflict-related deaths has improved significantly over the past decade, but important challenges remain. Accurately identifying whether victims are civilians or not, especially during intense hostilities, is often difficult. In 2025, the status of more than 13,000 conflict-related deaths could not be established. As a result, the figures presented should be interpreted as a minimum count of civilian deaths.

Figure 1: Number of documented conflict-related deaths and annual change in civilian deaths, 2015-2025



Source: OHCHR

¹ For the 2015-2025 period, UN Human Rights could document conflict-related deaths, with a focus on civilian deaths, for 20 armed conflicts: Afghanistan, Burkina Faso, Cameroon, Central African Republic, Colombia, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Iraq, Lebanon, Libya, Mali, Myanmar, Philippines, the Occupied Palestinian Territory and Israel, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan, Syrian Arab Republic, Ukraine and Yemen. This list is compiled solely for reporting on SDG indicator 16.1.2 (conflict - related deaths) and is based on the methodology established for that indicator. Inclusion or exclusion of a context from this list does not constitute a legal determination or official position regarding its classification as an armed conflict or the applicability of international humanitarian law.

² The increase in 2024 is partly attributable to newly accessible records following the change in regime in the Syrian Arab Republic. While further verification is pending, it is likely that a significant proportion of the deaths recorded in 2024 took place in preceding years.

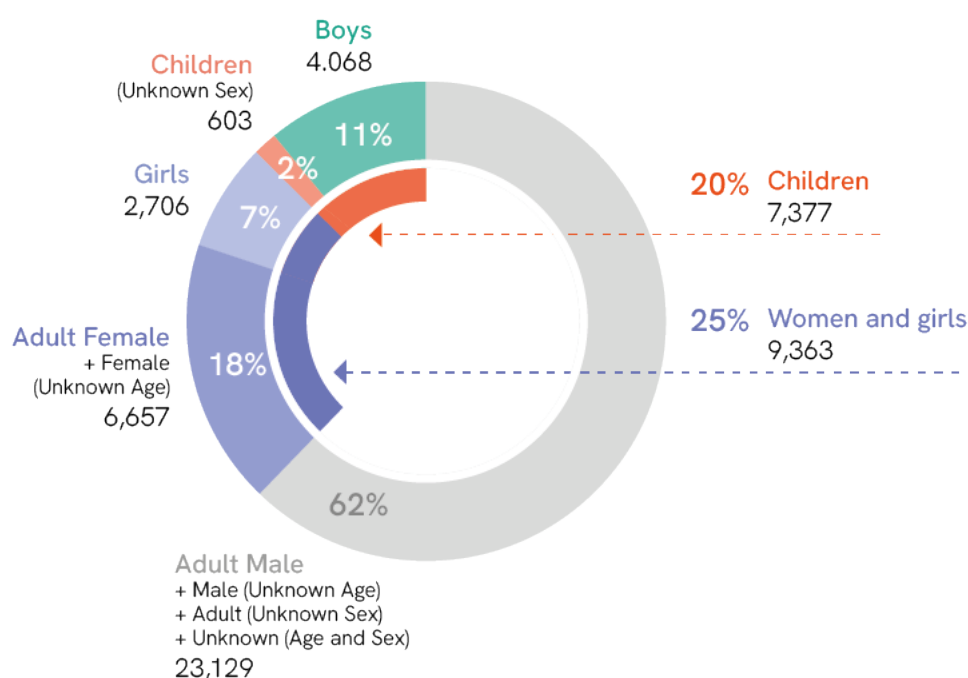


Although data are limited, where the cause of death could be identified, heavy weapons and explosive munitions were responsible for 40 per cent of civilian deaths, followed by small arms and light weapons at 20 per cent. These findings highlight the continued use of highly destructive weaponry, often used in populated areas.

Women and children accounted for 38 per cent of documented civilian deaths

The impact of conflict is not experienced equally across population groups. In 2025, women represented 18 per cent of documented civilian deaths, and children 20 per cent, together accounting for 38 per cent of all documented deaths. Among child victims, three boys were killed for every two girls. However, patterns of exposure and risk differ across conflict settings. In Myanmar, for example, women and girls accounted for 43 per cent of documented civilian deaths, compared with a global average of 25 per cent.

Figure 2: Documented civilian conflict-related deaths by age and sex, 2025



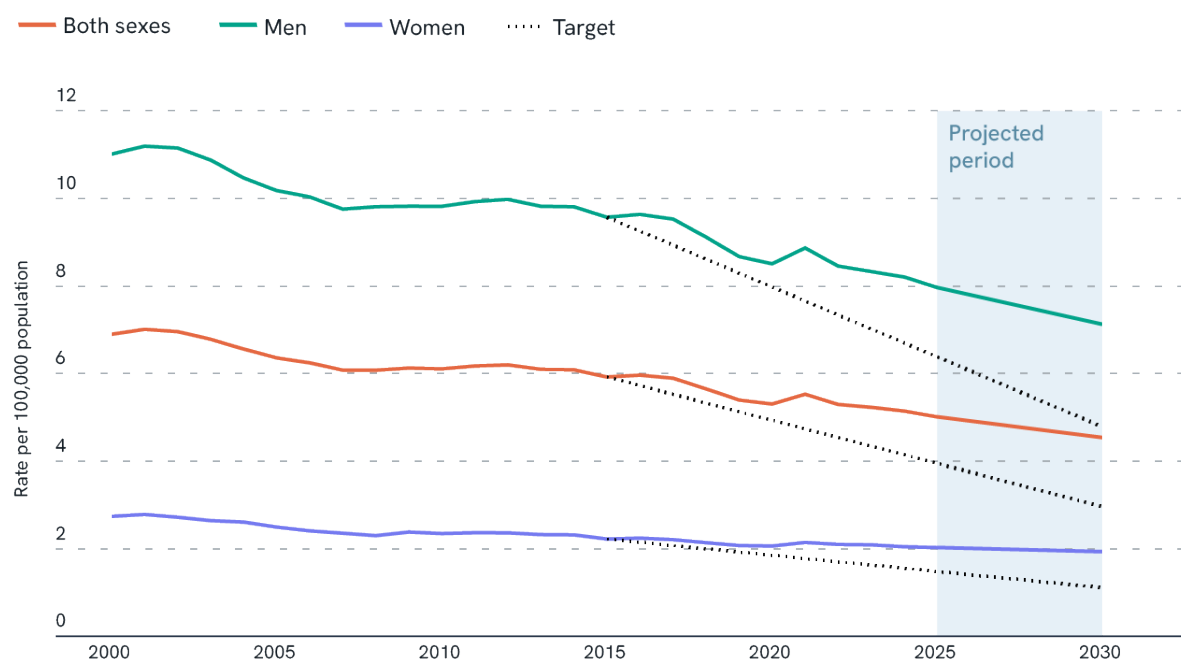
Source: OHCHR

Conflict undermines development far beyond the loss of life. It weakens state capacity, destroys critical infrastructure, undermines economic growth, diverts scarce resources away from development, weakens institutions, and erodes human security, often with consequences that last long after conflict ends. The frequency, duration, and intensity of armed conflicts also drive displacement and destroy livelihoods.

Global homicide rates continue to decline, but the world remains off track to significantly reduce violence by 2030

Between 2015 and 2024, the global homicide rate declined by 13.2 per cent, from 5.9 to 5.1 victims per 100,000 population. If current trends continue, the rate is projected to fall to around 4.5 victims per 100,000 population by 2030. While this would represent important progress, it would fall short of the SDG 16 ambition to achieve a 50 per cent reduction in the global homicide rate from its 2015 level by 2030. This would require the global homicide rate to fall below 3 victims per 100,000 population.

Figure 3: Trends in and projections of the global homicide rate (per 100,000 population), by sex (2000–2030)



Source: UNODC

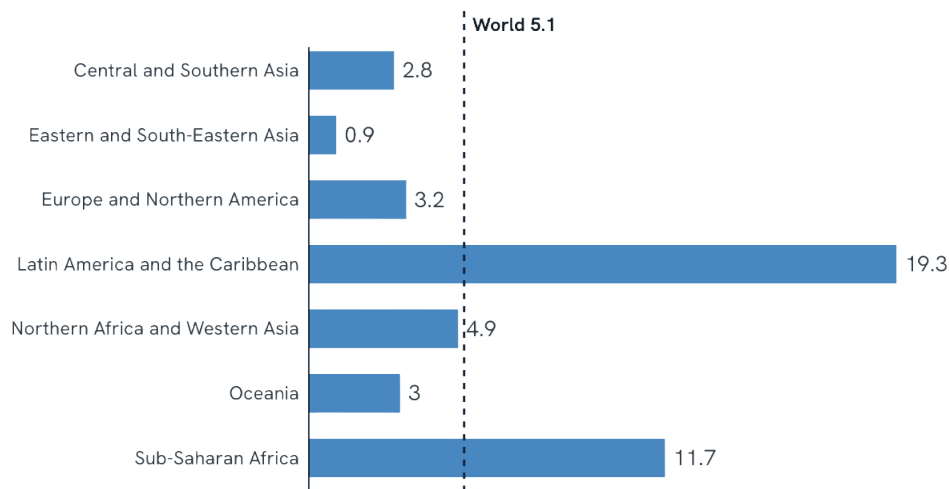
Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems (UN-CTS) and data from other sources reviewed by Member States. Projections for years 2025–2030 represent a linear extrapolation of trends observed between 2015 and 2024. The black dotted line indicates the trend required to achieve the SDG Target 16.1 objective of halving the global homicide rate by 2030.

Latin America and the Caribbean and Sub-Saharan Africa account for two-thirds of all homicide victims

Progress is uneven across regions. In 2024, Latin America and the Caribbean recorded the highest homicide rate globally, at 19.3 victims per 100,000 population, almost four times the global average, and accounted for just above 30 per cent of all estimated 420,000 homicide victims worldwide. The region continues to be disproportionately affected by organized crime and gang-related violence. Sub-Saharan Africa recorded the second highest homicide rate, at an estimated 11.7 victims per 100,000 population, although estimates remain subject to greater uncertainty due to data gaps. In absolute terms, Sub-Saharan Africa bore the largest burden of intentional homicide, with an estimated 145,000 victims, the highest

regional total globally. By contrast, all other regions recorded homicide rates below the global average, highlighting stark regional inequalities in exposure to lethal violence.

Figure 4: Rate of intentional homicide per 100,000 population, by region (2024)



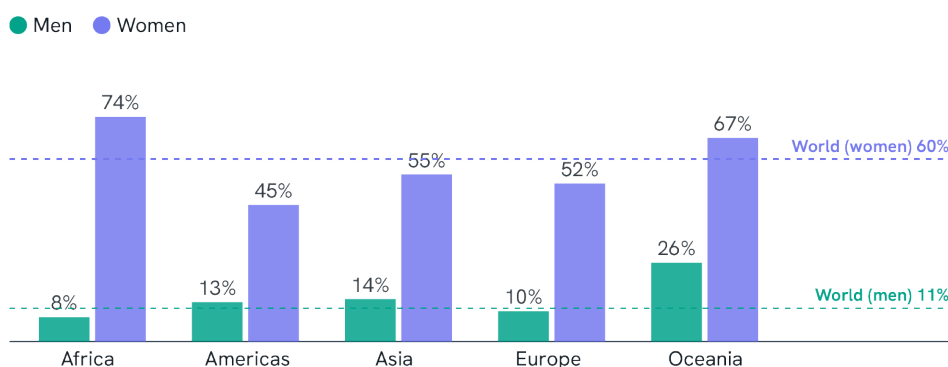
Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems and data from other sources reviewed by Member States.

Nearly 60 per cent of all women killed in 2024 were victims of an intimate partner or family member

Although men accounted for an estimated 80 per cent of homicide victims in 2024, women faced a markedly different pattern of risk. Nearly 60 per cent of women intentionally killed globally were killed by an intimate partner or family member, compared with just 11 per cent of male homicide victims. While men are disproportionately affected by lethal violence in public settings, women continue to face the greatest risk of lethal violence within their own homes. The share of women victims of an intimate partner or family member was highest in Africa, followed by Oceania, and lowest in the Americas.

Figure 5: Share of victims of intimate partner/family member homicide among all victims of homicide, by region and sex (2024)



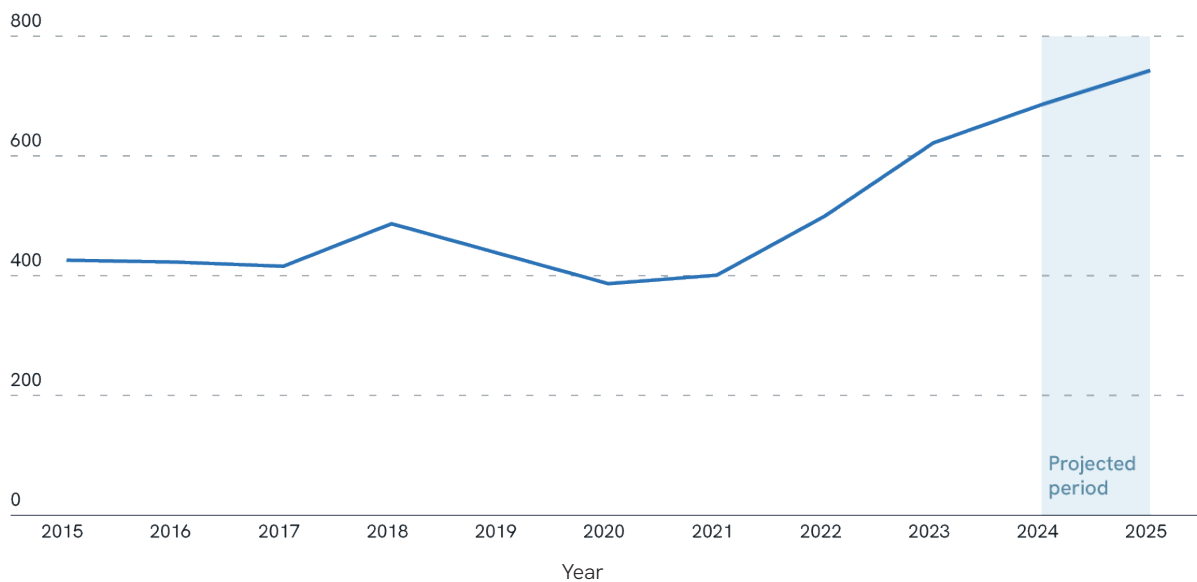
Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems and data from other sources reviewed by Member States. Data on the share of intimate partner/family member homicide out of all homicides is not available for SDG regions.

One human rights defender, journalist, or trade unionist is killed or disappeared every 10 hours

New evidence shows that verified killings³ of human rights defenders, journalists, and trade unionists have increased globally since 2015, signalling that the world is moving further away from the ambition to protect those who defend and promote fundamental freedoms. Since 2015, at least 5,995 defenders have been killed, and more than half of all UN Member States (115 countries) have recorded at least one killing. Annual verified numbers of killings are now at least 61 per cent higher than a decade ago.

Figure 6: Number of verified killings of human rights defenders, journalists and trade unionists worldwide, 2015 – 2025 (2025 figures projected)



Source: OHCHR

The latest data indicate that the situation continues to worsen. In 2024, a record 888 defenders were killed or disappeared, including 686 killings and 202 disappearances. This is equivalent to one defender, journalist or trade unionist being killed or disappeared every 10 hours, compared with every 19 hours in 2015. Based on historical patterns in human rights violation discovery and recording, the final number of documented cases for 2025 is expected to reach an estimated 743 killings and 202 disappearances.

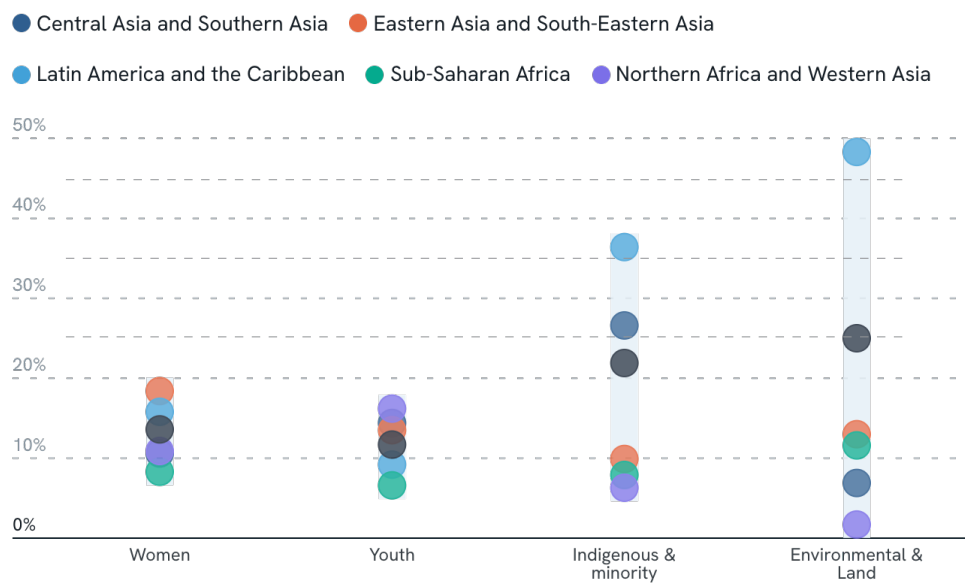
Violence against defenders is a global phenomenon, but the burden remains highly concentrated. Over the last decade, Latin America and the Caribbean accounted for roughly 60 per cent of all verified killings recorded. Over the same period, Northern

³ The term “verified” refers to a reported case that contains a minimum set of relevant information on a person, which have been reviewed by mandated bodies, mechanisms, and institutions and provided them with reasonable grounds to believe that that person was a victim of human rights violations or abuses.

Africa and Western Asia have experienced a rapid escalation, with their share of global killings nearly doubling to 27 per cent in 2025.

Over the 2023 - 2025 period, one in ten defenders killed or disappeared worldwide was a woman. Defenders working on environmental and land issues accounted for nearly three in ten recorded cases, while one in five victims belonged to Indigenous or minority groups. These patterns highlight how structural inequalities intersect with risks faced by various groups defending fundamental freedoms.

Figure 7: : Share of killed or disappeared human rights defenders belonging to selected group, by region (2025)



Source: OHCHR

Note: Each dot represents the share of defenders killed or disappeared in that region who belonged to the specified group. Categories are not mutually exclusive; an individual may be included in more than one group. Europe and Northern America are excluded due to small case numbers, and Oceania due to insufficient data availability.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

Documentation of attacks against human rights defenders, journalists, and trade unionists has improved significantly over the past decade. However, underreporting remains a challenge, particularly where access is restricted, reporting carries significant risks or documentation capacity is limited. The verified counts captured by this indicator should therefore be distinguished from true incidence of attacks, which remains unobserved and is likely higher than documented figures. Rather than measuring the full extent of violations, verified counts reflect the capacity of local and global actors to observe, record, and verify such attacks. Higher numbers of documented cases may indicate stronger reporting, monitoring, and verification systems, including the presence of strong civil society organizations, independent media, and national human rights institutions. Conversely, low or absent counts may reflect restrictions on civic space, limited reporting capacity, or barriers to verification, rather than an absence of violations. Reporting capacity can vary substantially both across countries and within countries over time. Continued investment in verification capacity and improved methodologies to identify victim groups and types of attacks, and to estimate the extent of unreported cases is essential to provide a more complete picture of violence against those defending fundamental freedoms.

Data on arbitrarily detained human rights defenders drives action that may help secure earlier release

A pilot analysis of cases recorded under SDG indicator 16.10.1, which tracks the number of verified cases of killing, kidnapping, enforced disappearance, arbitrary detention, and torture of journalists, media personnel, trade unionists, and human rights advocates, suggests that UN action, informed by data collected to monitor this indicator, may help correct arbitrary deprivation of liberty by securing the earlier release of detained human rights defenders.

The pilot examined a random sample of arbitrary detention cases recorded between 2020 and 2025 for which an official UN Special Procedures Communication had been issued. Half of the defenders saw their arbitrary deprivation of liberty end within approximately three months of the Communication (92 days), with some released in as little as two days. This finding is significant when set against a median detention length of 8 months (243 days) across the sampled cases.

Critically, this was not merely a shortening of unlawful detention: more than one third of defenders (35 per cent) were acquitted and released following the Communication. In these cases, the arbitrariness of the detention was formally corrected and the right to liberty fully restored, rather than the detention ending on conditional terms or amid continued judicial harassment.

The cases span a wide geographical reach, reflecting that this UN mechanism engages effectively worldwide: 30 per cent in Sub-Saharan Africa, 30 per cent in Central and Southern Asia, 25 per cent in Latin America and the Caribbean, 10 per cent in Northern Africa and Western Asia, and 1 per cent in Europe and Northern America.

The pilot findings should be interpreted as preliminary. A full-scale study by OHCHR and partners is forthcoming to test the causal nature of the relationships suggested by this pilot. Nevertheless, the analysis reminds us that data are far more than statistics — they speak first to human beings, to their right to liberty as enshrined in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and to whether that right is upheld in practice. They also underscore the importance of State-agreed mechanisms to protect human rights defenders.

The forthcoming broader study may help show whether international protection mechanisms are making a measurable difference in people's lives and their right to liberty. Strengthening these data systems therefore has the potential to improve both accountability and the evidence base for action.

KEY NUMBERS

92 days

The point by which half of the human rights defenders had been released from arbitrary detention following a UN Special Procedures Communication.

35%

of defenders were acquitted and released, not just conditionally freed, following a UN Special Procedures Communication.



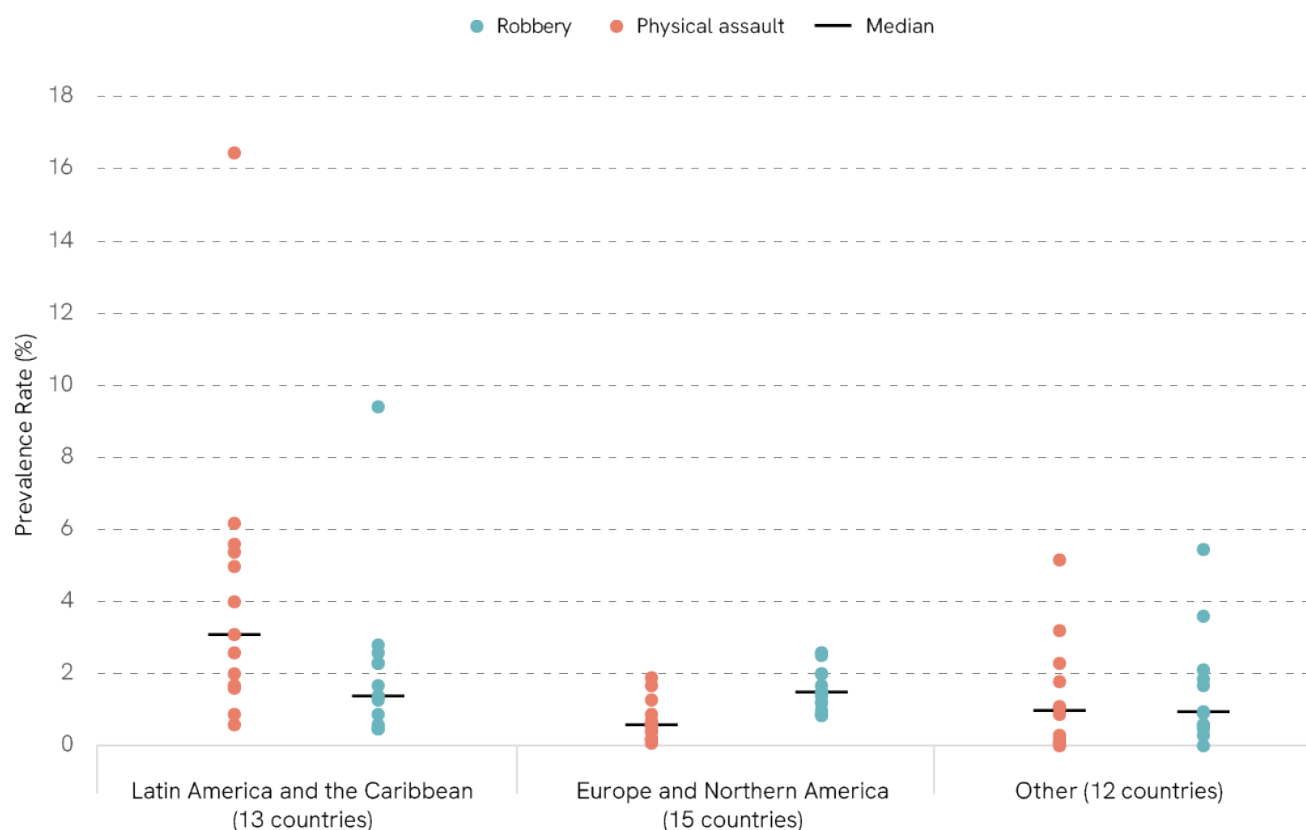
Millions of people experience non-lethal violence, with distinct regional and gendered patterns of victimization

Non-lethal violence affects millions of people each year and has wide-ranging negative impacts on individuals and societies. Beyond the immediate harm, experiences of violence can cause lasting physical and mental health issues, generate adverse economic effects such as lower educational outcomes or increased poverty, and limit victims' social participation and economic life, with effects that often persist throughout victims' lives.

Unlike homicide and conflict-related deaths, most experiences of non-lethal violence are never reported to the police or other authorities. Household victimization surveys therefore play a critical role in revealing experiences of violence that remain largely invisible in official administrative records.

Available survey data suggest that levels of experience of physical assault are relatively similar across regions, with the median prevalence rates ranging from 0.9 to 1.5 per cent of the population. Robbery shows a different pattern. In Latin America and the Caribbean, the median prevalence rate reached 3.1 per cent, more than three times the levels recorded in other regions, where median prevalence rates remained below 1 per cent.

Figure 8: Proportion of the population subjected to robbery and physical assault in the previous twelve months, by region (latest available year since 2015)



Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems and data from other sources reviewed by Member States. Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence.

Women face higher risks of sexual violence, while men are more likely to experience higher levels of physical violence.

Patterns of victimization differ markedly between women and men. Across 18 countries with available data, women were consistently more likely than men to experience sexual violence. The median prevalence of sexual violence among women was 2.9 per cent, compared with 0.4 per cent among men. By contrast, men experienced slightly higher levels of physical violence, with a median prevalence of 4.2 per cent compared with 3.2 per cent among women in the 51 countries with data globally. Data on psychological violence remain too limited for global analysis. Available evidence, however, suggests relatively similar prevalence levels among women and men.

Figure 9: Proportion of the population subjected to violence in the previous twelve months, by sex (latest available year between 2016 - 2024)



Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems and data from other sources reviewed by Member States. Data based on the latest available year of survey data between 2016 and 2024 for 51 countries (physical violence), 18 countries (sexual violence), 12 countries (psychological violence). Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence, or the midpoint across countries: half of countries with available data have a higher prevalence and half have a lower prevalence.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

Since 2015, 95 countries have reported data for at least one form of non-lethal violence, although country coverage remains uneven across regions and across different forms of violence. Robbery and physical assault are available for the largest number of countries, with 80 countries having reported data for at least one year since 2015. By contrast, only 18 countries reported data for psychological violence for at least one year since 2015. Continued investment in standardized victimization surveys is essential to improve the availability, comparability, and quality of data on non-lethal violence.



DATA TO IMPACT STORY

How victimization surveys are shaping citizen security policies in panama

Nearly a decade after implementing its first official National Victimization Survey (ENVIP), Panama is preparing a new round of survey. Building on the experience of 2017, the updated survey is expanding its scope to address emerging security challenges, including cybercrime, firearm possession, and physical and sexual harassment. The new data collection reflects the country's commitment to maintaining an evidence-based approach to citizen security and ensuring that statistical systems evolve alongside changing crime patterns.

Panama's decision to institutionalize victimization surveys stems from the demonstrated policy value of the 2017 ENVIP. According to the Ministry of Public Security, the survey findings contributed directly to the reformulation of the national citizen security strategy and informed discussions within the Technical Prevention Board, composed of eight ministries responsible for crime prevention policies. By providing common evidence based on crime prevalence, underreporting, perceptions of insecurity, and corruption, the survey enabled a more coordinated and preventive approach to citizen security across government institutions.

One of the most notable findings revealed that more people experienced bribery than any other measured form of victimization. This highlights the importance of measuring security challenges beyond crimes reported to the police and expanding the national security debate beyond conventional street crime and placing integrity and governance issues at the centre of public policy discussions.

The experience also highlighted the importance of strong institutional partnerships. Both rounds of the ENVIP have been developed through a strategic collaboration between the Ministry of Public Security, through the National Integrated Criminal Statistics System (SIEC), and the National Institute of Statistics and Census (INEC). Through the Latin America and Caribbean Survey Initiative (LACSI), the [UNODC-INEGI Center of Excellence](#) has provided technical assistance in both survey rounds, supporting methodological harmonization and the production of internationally comparable statistics.

Today, Panama stands among the 14 countries in Latin America and the Caribbean that have implemented a victimization survey, contributing to a growing regional effort to strengthen official statistics on crime and victimization. The Panamanian experience demonstrates how partnerships

KEY NUMBERS

2017

Year of Panama's first National Victimization Survey (ENVIP)

14

Countries in Latin America and the Caribbean with a victimization survey



between security institutions, national statistical offices, and international organizations can transform data into action. It also highlights how reliable victimization data can transform statistics into policies that improve people's safety and trust in institutions.

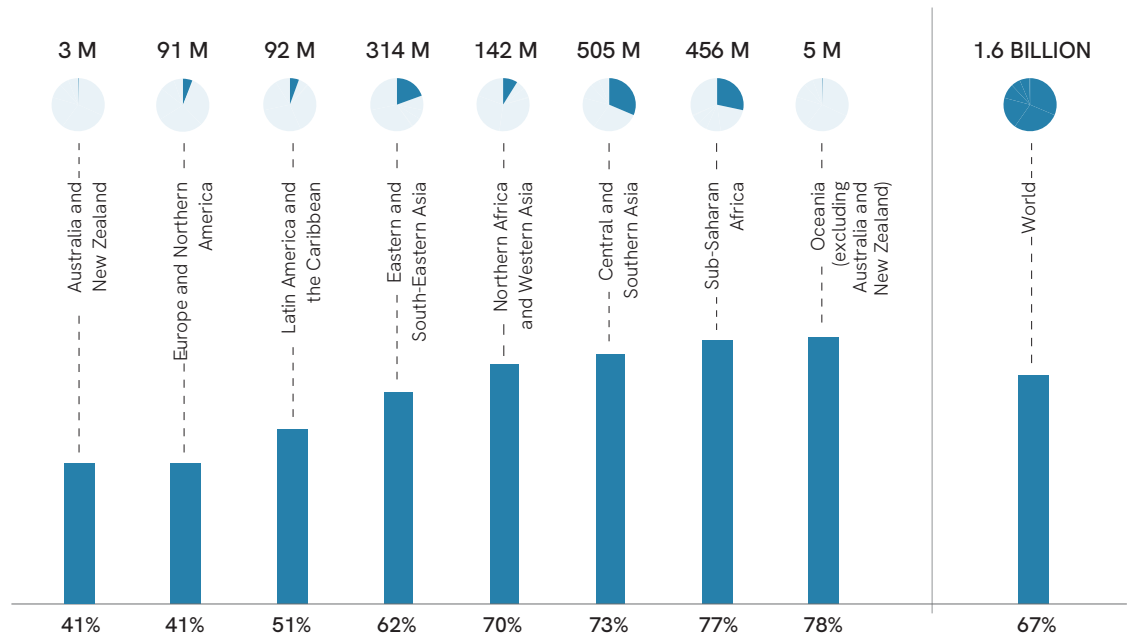
SDG INDICATOR 16.2.1 AND 16.2.3 - VIOLENCE AGAINST CHILDREN

Violence begins early in life, with 1.6 billion children experiencing violent discipline at home

Violence remains a pervasive reality for millions of children around the world, cutting across geographical, cultural, and economic boundaries. It can take many forms and occurs in any setting where children spend time.

An estimated 1.6 billion children, around two in three globally, experience violent punishment by caregivers at home.^{4,5} While physical punishment or psychological aggression in the context of discipline at home is widespread across all regions, Central and Southern Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa together account for more than half of all affected children worldwide. In most countries, boys and girls are equally likely to experience violent discipline at home.⁶

Figure 10: Percentage (bar) and global share (pie) of children experiencing violent discipline in the past month, by region (2010-2024)



Source: UNICEF

Notes: Data are drawn from the UNICEF global databases, 2025, based on Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys, Demographic and Health Surveys, and other nationally representative surveys that use a comparable methodology. These national data are also included in the official global database for SDG indicator 16.2.1. See the source publication for other technical notes on data sources, coverage and methods.

4 [United Nations Children's Fund, Data Brief on Violence against Children at Home, UNICEF, 2025](#)

5 All of the estimates are based on data collected between 2010 and 2024 for a subset of 102 countries covering 52 per cent of the global population of children under age 18.

6 [United Nations Children's Fund, A Familiar Face: Violence in the lives of children and adolescents, UNICEF, New York, 2017](#)

An estimated 370 million girls and women have experienced rape or sexual assault during childhood

Violence experienced during childhood extends beyond violent discipline in the home. Globally, more than 370 million women and girls, around one in eight alive today, experienced rape or sexual assault as children. Among men and boys, an estimated 240 to 310 million (or around one in eleven) experienced rape or sexual assault in childhood. The risks are even greater in fragile settings, where more than one in four girls have experienced rape or sexual assault in their childhood.⁷



DATA CONSIDERATIONS

Despite improvements in data availability, many countries still lack data on the full scale and nature of the issue and major data gaps remain on some forms of violence experienced by children, such as sexual violence. Continued investment in nationally led data collection harmonized to a common statistical standard and stronger national statistical systems are essential to improve the quality, comparability, and timeliness of global data on violence against children.

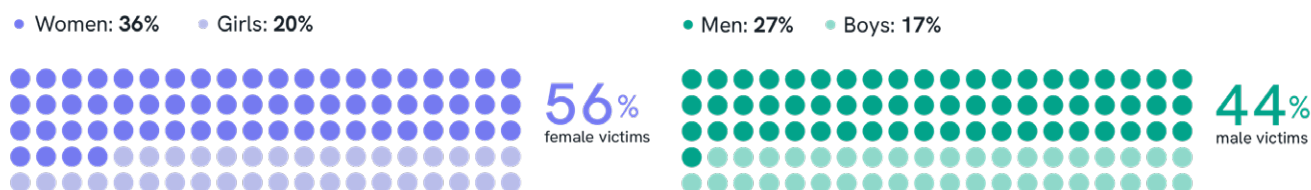
SDG INDICATOR 16.2.2 - TRAFFICKING IN PERSONS

More than one in three detected victims of human trafficking are children

Human trafficking continues to affect women, men, and children in every region of the world. Yet it remains one of the most hidden forms of crime, making it inherently difficult to measure. Many victims never come to the attention of authorities, and official statistics capture only detected cases. The figures presented here should therefore be interpreted as a minimum estimate of the true scale of trafficking.

Following a temporary decline during the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic, the number of detected victims of trafficking has continued to increase globally. Children accounted for 37 per cent of all detected victims in 2024, nearly three times the share recorded two decades earlier (13 per cent in 2004). Among child victims, girls represented a slightly larger share than boys. Among adult victims, women continued to account for a significantly larger share than men.

Figure 11: Share of detected victims of trafficking, by victim, sex, and age (2024 or most recent year available)

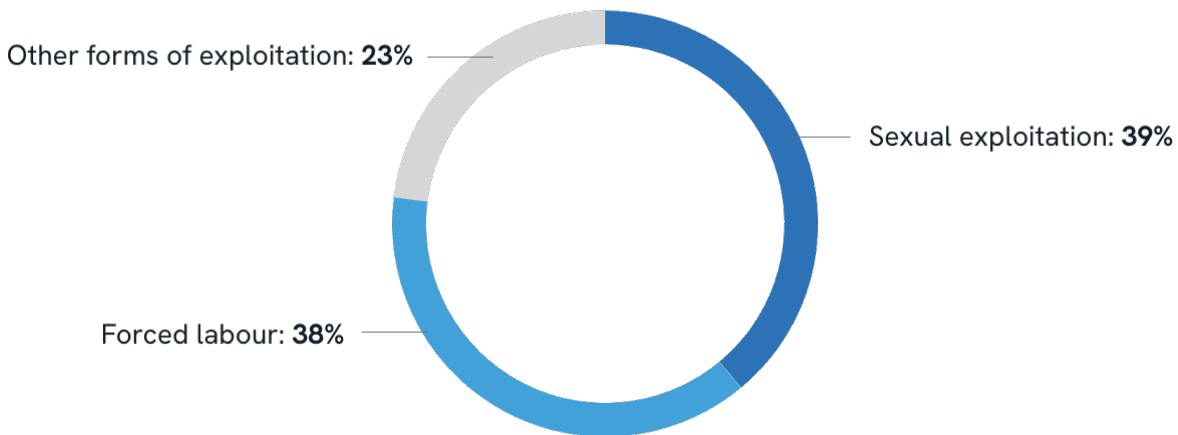


Source: UNODC

7 All estimates on sexual violence in childhood are from [United Nations Children's Fund, When Numbers Demand Action: Confronting the global scale of sexual violence against children, UNICEF, New York, 2024.](#)

Sexual exploitation and forced labour remained the two most commonly detected forms of trafficking, accounting for roughly 39 per cent and 38 per cent of detected victims, respectively. The remaining victims were trafficked for other forms of exploitation, including organ removal, forced criminality, forced marriage, forced begging, etc.

Figure 12: Share of detected victims of trafficking, by form of exploitation (2024 or most recent year available)



Source: UNODC

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

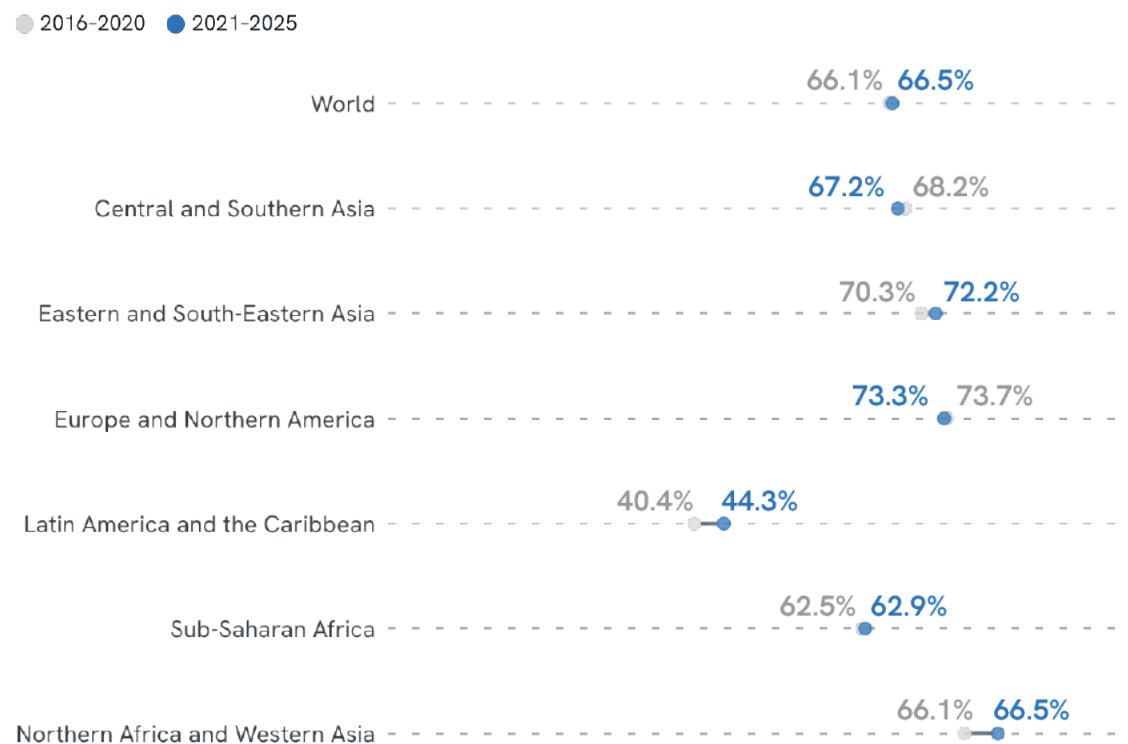
Human trafficking is a clear example of a challenge that no institution can address alone. Effective responses require national and international cooperation, as well as cross-border data sharing, as trafficking networks often operate across jurisdictions. At the same time, because trafficking remains hidden, continued investment in administrative data systems, statistical methods and victims' surveys is critical to better understand its scale, identify those at greatest risk and strengthen evidence-based responses.

SDG INDICATOR 16.1.4 - PERCEPTION OF SAFETY

One in three people globally do not feel safe walking alone at night

Peace is measured not only by the absence of violence, but also by whether people feel safe in their daily lives. Yet around one in three people globally do not feel safe walking alone in their neighbourhood after dark, a proportion that has remained broadly unchanged since 2017. Perceptions of safety were lowest in Latin America and the Caribbean, where more than half of the population reported feeling unsafe walking alone after dark.

Figure 13: Proportion of the population that feel safe walking alone at night around the area they live in, by region and period (2016–2020 and 2021–2025)



Source: UNODC, Gallup World Poll

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems, Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys, and the Gallup World Poll. Regional aggregates refer to 3-year averages weighted by countries' population size. Most surveys include the qualifications "after dark" or "at night" in the question wording. Data coverage: Averages for Oceania were removed, as only data for one country were available.

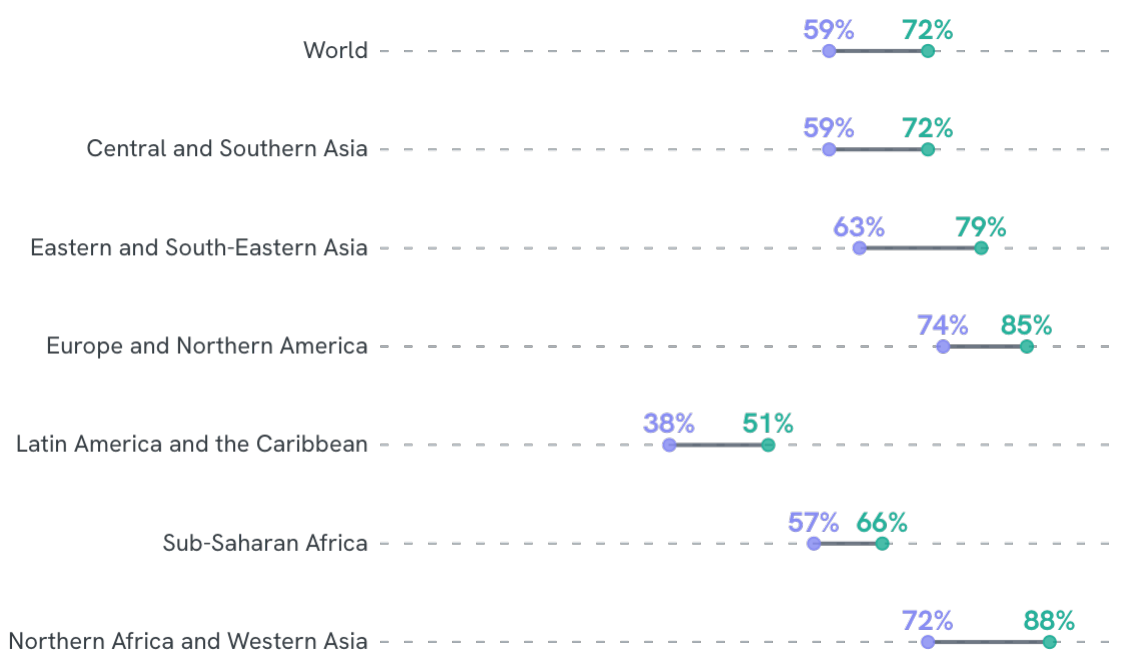
Women consistently indicate feeling less safe than men

Women consistently indicate feeling less safe than men across all regions. Across 74 countries with sex-disaggregated data,⁸ 59 per cent of women reported feeling safe walking alone after dark, compared with 72 per cent of men. The gender gap was evident in every region and was particularly pronounced in Northern Africa and Western Asia.

As women are generally less likely than men to be victims of intentional homicide, these findings suggest that perceptions of safety reflect more than exposure to lethal violence. Experiences and risks of non-lethal violence, including sexual violence, harassment, and robbery, as well as broader social and environmental factors, may also influence how women perceive safety in everyday life.

⁸ The number of countries with sex-disaggregated data on perception of safety is different to the sample of countries with data on the overall perception of safety in the population.

Figure 14: Proportion of the population that feel safe walking alone at night around the area they live in, by region and sex (2021-2025)



Source: UNODC, Gallup World Poll

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems, Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys, and the Gallup World Poll. Regional aggregates refer to 3-year averages weighted by countries' population size. Most surveys include the qualifications "after dark" or "at night" in the question wording. Averages for Oceania were removed, as only data for one country was available.



The role of institutions in promoting peace

The evidence presented across these indicators underscore the important role of institutions in preventing conflict and violence. While the forms of violence differ, from conflict-related deaths and homicide to violence against children, human trafficking and attacks on those defending human rights, outcomes are shaped by the ability of institutions to prevent violence, protect victims, enforce the rule of law, and uphold fundamental rights.

Disagreements and competing interests are an inevitable feature of any society. Violence

and armed conflict are not. Whether societies experience violence, insecurity, and fear depends in large part on the ability of institutions to manage grievances peacefully, deliver justice fairly, provide security, and safeguard fundamental freedoms. Effective institutions create peaceful pathways for resolving disputes, seeking justice, and holding power to account without resorting to violence. When institutions are weak, inaccessible or non-inclusive, grievances are more likely to go unresolved, trust erodes, and the risk of violence becomes more difficult to prevent.



2. Justice

Justice is a cornerstone of peaceful, inclusive, and resilient societies. It ensures that people are treated equally under the law, that their rights are protected, and that disputes can be resolved fairly and peacefully. Under Goal 16, justice is measured through people's ability to access justice institutions, the extent to which laws are applied equally, and whether public institutions are accountable for their actions.

At its core, justice is about whether people can obtain fair and just outcomes when their rights are violated. Yet for millions, justice remains beyond reach. Around the world, victims of robbery, physical assault and sexual violence do not report crimes through formal mechanisms, with fewer than half seeking justice through official channels. Civil justice also remains inaccessible for many people facing disputes over their homes, livelihoods, or families. Even when people enter the justice system, fair treatment is not guaranteed. Globally, around one third of people in prison have not been convicted of a crime but remain detained while awaiting trial - a proportion that has changed little over the past decade.

Justice also depends on whether decisions are guided by the rule of law rather than by money, influence, or

political power. Across the world, bribery remains a reality for many individuals seeking essential public services and for businesses interacting with public authorities. At the same time, illicit financial flows divert resources away from development, weaken public institutions, and undermine confidence that laws are applied equally to all.

Strong, accountable, and independent institutions are essential for ensuring justice and safeguarding human rights. National Human Rights Institutions (NHRIs) play a vital role in protecting human rights, holding governments accountable, and ensuring that justice extends to all members of society. Although progress has slowed in recent years, earlier gains have largely been sustained. In 2025, 89 countries had established an NHRI that was fully compliant with the Paris Principles,⁹ up from 70 countries in 2015, demonstrating the value of sustained investment in independent oversight and accountable governance.

Taken together, these indicators measure more than the performance of courts or legal systems. They reveal whether institutions can resolve disputes fairly, uphold rights, enforce accountability, and ensure that justice is for all.

⁹ The Paris Principles are the internationally agreed standards for National Human Rights Institutions (NHRIs), adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in 1993 (resolution 48/134).

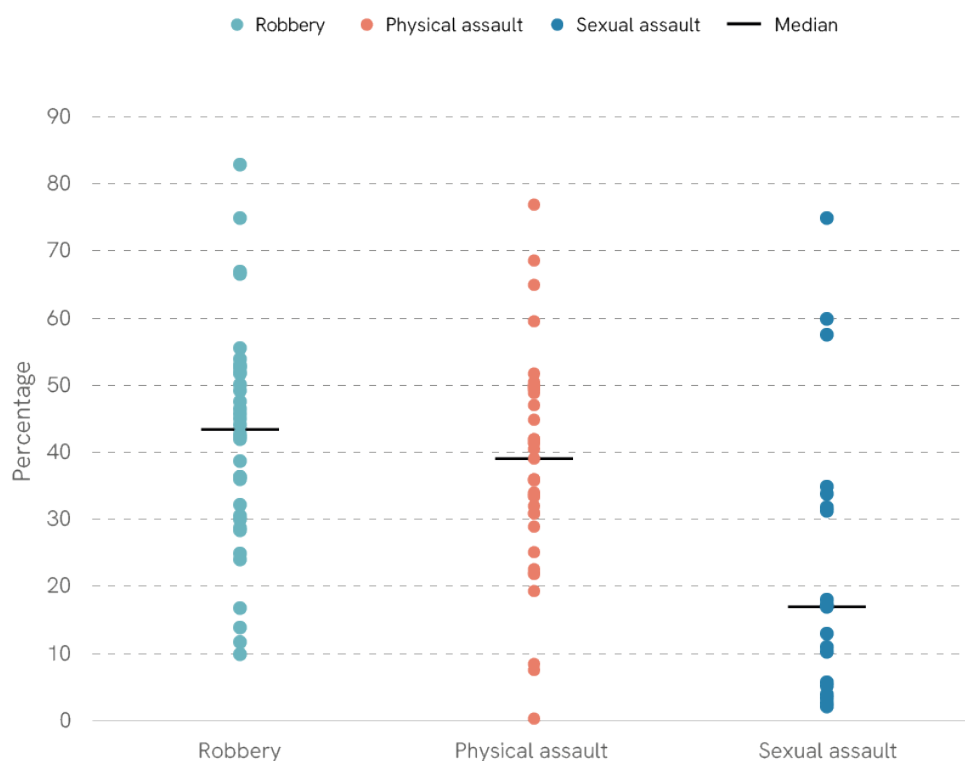
More than half of violent crimes remain hidden from the justice system

Reporting violence to the police or other competent authorities is the first step towards justice. When victims do not report their experiences, perpetrators are less likely to be investigated or held accountable, and violence remains largely invisible to the justice system. Whether victims come forward depends not only on the nature of the offence, but also on whether victims believe authorities will respond fairly, effectively, and without causing further harm.

Victims of sexual assault are far less likely to report their experience than victims of physical assault or robbery

Across countries with available data, more than half of victims of violence do not report their experiences to the police or other competent authorities, and reporting patterns vary widely. The median reporting rate was 43 per cent for robbery and 39 per cent for physical assault, but only 17 per cent for sexual assault. The especially low reporting of sexual assault is consistent with evidence pointing to multiple barriers to reporting such as stigma, fear of retaliation, lack of confidence in the justice system, and previous negative experiences with the authorities.

Figure 15: Proportion of victims of violence in the previous 12 months who reported their victimization, by type of crime (2025 or latest available year since 2015)



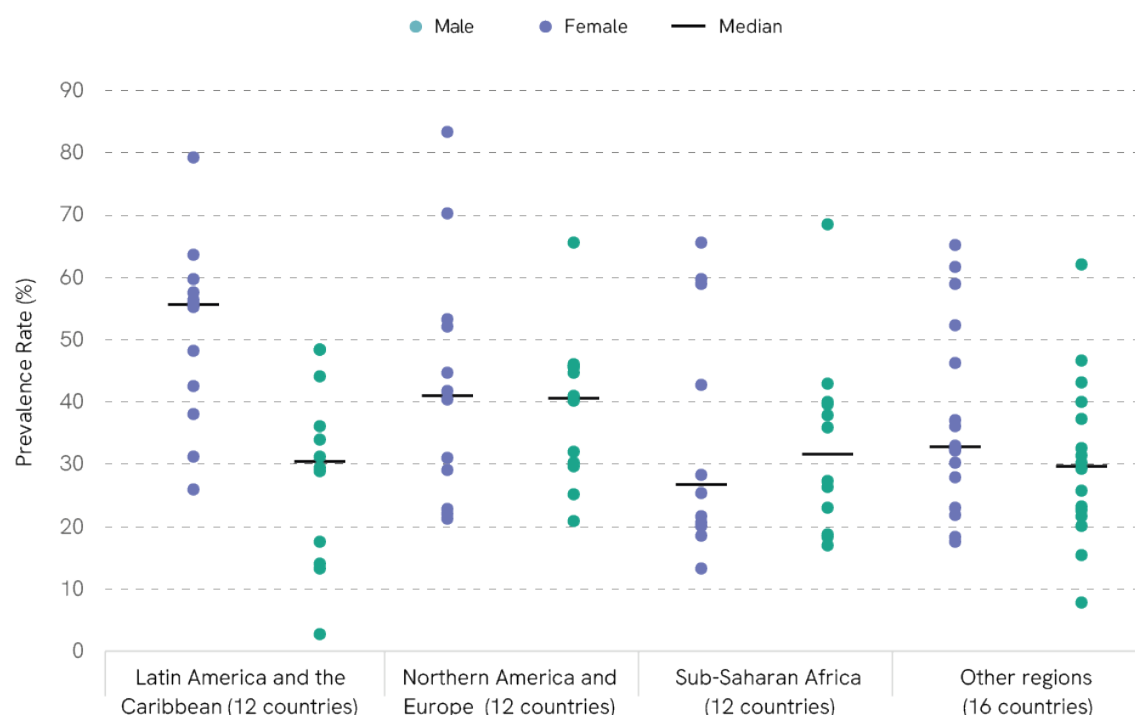
Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems and data from other sources reviewed by Member States. Data available for 39 countries (physical assault), 36 countries (robbery), 19 countries (sexual assault). Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence.



Sex-disaggregated data remain limited globally, but available evidence suggests that reporting behaviour may differ between women and men in some regions. Across 12 countries in Latin America and the Caribbean with available data, the median reporting rate for physical assault was 56 per cent for women compared with 30 per cent for men. Such clear differences are not observed in the limited data available for other regions.

Figure 16: Proportion of victims of physical assault in the previous 12 months who reported their victimization, by sex and region (2024 or latest available year since 2016)



Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems and data from other sources reviewed by Member States. Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

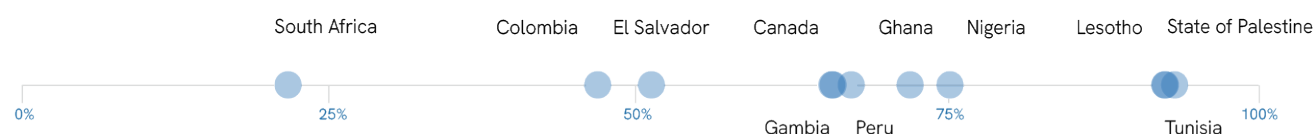
Because many victims never report experiences of violence to the authorities, administrative records from the police or courts capture only a fraction of violent incidents. For these reasons, data on access to criminal justice comes primarily from crime victimization surveys or victimization modules integrated into household surveys, which capture both officially reported and unreported experiences of violence. As of early 2026, 81 countries had produced at least one data point on reporting of physical, sexual, or psychological violence since 2015. Data availability remains uneven across forms of violence. Comparable information is available for a larger number of countries for robbery (39 countries) and physical assault (36 countries), while far fewer countries (19) have collected comparable data on sexual assault. These gaps continue to limit the global comparability and representativeness of estimates across different types of victimization.

An estimated 5 billion have unmet justice needs, yet access to civil justice remains one of the least measured areas of Goal 16

Civil justice affects people's everyday lives. Disputes over housing, employment, land, inheritance, or family matters can have profound consequences for millions of people every day. Whether these disputes can be resolved fairly and effectively is fundamental to protecting rights, preventing conflicts from escalating, and promoting social and economic well-being. Global estimates suggest that more than 5 billion people worldwide experience unmet justice needs, which means they cannot obtain justice for everyday civil, administrative, or criminal justice problems, cannot access the opportunities and protections provided by the law, or live in extreme conditions of injustice.¹⁰ Recent progress in measuring access to criminal justice has helped shed light on some of these challenges. More than 80 countries have produced data on whether victims of violence report crimes to competent authorities, providing valuable insights into barriers to accessing formal justice systems. By contrast, access to civil justice remains one of the least measured areas of Goal 16. To date, only 11 countries have reported data on whether people facing civil disputes are able to access dispute-resolution mechanisms, limiting understanding of where barriers persist and which groups are being left behind.

Among countries with available data, access to dispute resolution varies considerably. In some countries, fewer than half of those who experienced a civil dispute sought resolution through formal or informal mechanisms, while in others almost everyone did. Although based on a limited number of countries, these findings suggest that access to civil justice differs substantially across national contexts and underscores the need for more systematic measurement and internationally comparable data.

Figure 17: Proportion of the population who have experienced a dispute in the past two years who accessed a formal or informal dispute resolution mechanism, across different countries (2025 or latest available year).



Source: OECD, UNDP and UNODC

Note: Data for South Africa refers to the proportion of the population who have experienced a dispute in the past two years. No aggregate indicator on the share of people who experienced a dispute and accessed a formal or informal dispute resolution mechanism was published. Data for Nigeria refer to the proportion of the population who have experienced a dispute in the past five years and who accessed a formal or informal dispute resolution mechanism.

¹⁰ [Measuring the Justice Gap: A People-Centered Assessment of Unmet Justice Needs Around the World, World Justice Project, 2023.](#)

The paper defines unmet justice needs as unmet needs that arise when people cannot defend or enforce their rights, or obtain a just resolution of their justiciable problems: 1) people who cannot obtain justice for everyday civil, administrative, or criminal justice problems; 2) people who are excluded from the opportunities the law provides; and 3) people who live in extreme conditions of injustice. Estimates were produced using legal needs survey data collected by the World Justice Project in 102 countries (representing 90.6 per cent of the world's population), data gathered by the Hague Institute of Innovation of Law in two countries, and extrapolations for 114 countries without legal needs survey data. For these countries, the proportion of the population with unmet legal needs was imputed based on the average of countries in the same region and income group.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

The Goal 16 indicator on access to civil justice was adopted and incorporated into the global SDG Framework in 2020. Its adoption coincided with the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, which severely disrupted data collection efforts worldwide, particularly household survey programmes that in many countries relied on face-to-face data collection. These disruptions delayed the methodological development of the indicator, and the data collection needed for its measurement across the globe. Expanding the implementation of the [SDG 16 Survey Initiative](#) or by integrating its access to civil justice module in nationally representative legal needs and governance surveys, is essential for strengthening global monitoring and identifying the populations most affected by unmet justice needs.

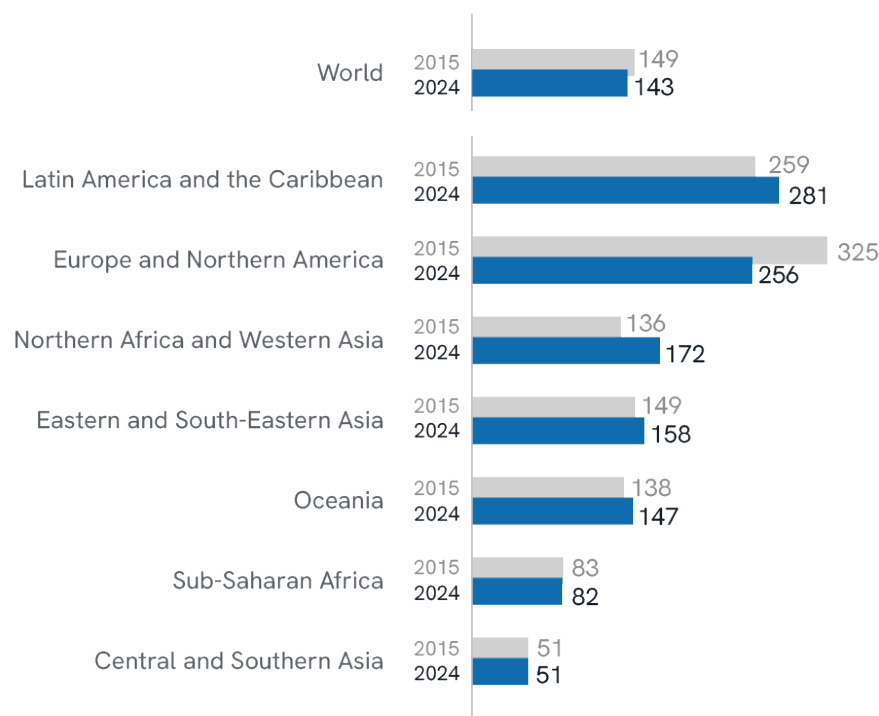


SDG 16.3.2 - UNSENTENCED DETENTION

One in three prisoners globally is held in detention without a sentence, with little progress over the past decade

The right to a fair and timely trial is a fundamental component of justice, enshrined in international human rights law. In 2024, an estimated 11.6 million people were held in detention worldwide, corresponding to a prison population rate of 143 prisoners per 100,000 population. Prison population rates varied considerably across regions, ranging from 51 prisoners per 100,000 population in Central and Southern Asia to 281 in Latin America and the Caribbean, the highest rate globally.

Figure 18: Number of sentenced and unsentenced detainees per 100,000 population (2015 and 2024)



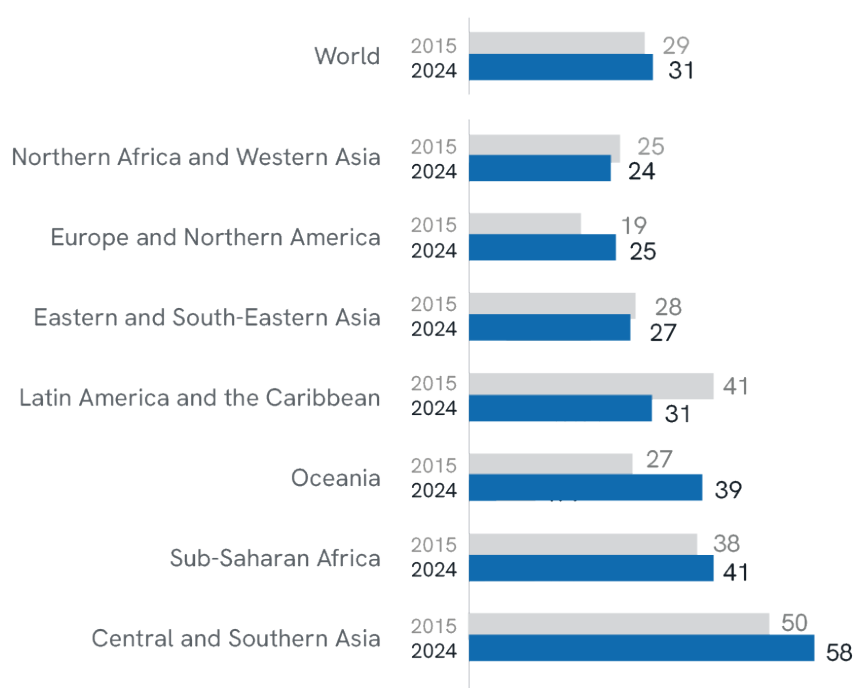
Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems, data from the World Prison Brief (Institute for Crime & Justice Policy Research) and national sources reviewed by Member States.



Despite efforts to strengthen access to justice and improve the efficiency of criminal justice systems, little progress has been made in reducing pre-trial detention globally. The share of unsentenced detainees has remained virtually unchanged over the past decade, at around 30 per cent, equivalent to approximately 3.6 million people, with an estimated 3.4 million men and 0.2 million women. Regional trends, however, varied considerably. Latin America and the Caribbean reduced the proportion of prisoners awaiting trial or sentencing from 41 per cent in 2015 to 31 per cent in 2024. By contrast, the situation deteriorated in Central and Southern Asia, where almost six in ten prisoners were unsentenced in 2024, up from five in ten in 2015.

Figure 19: Unsentenced detainees as a proportion of overall prison population (2015 and 2024)



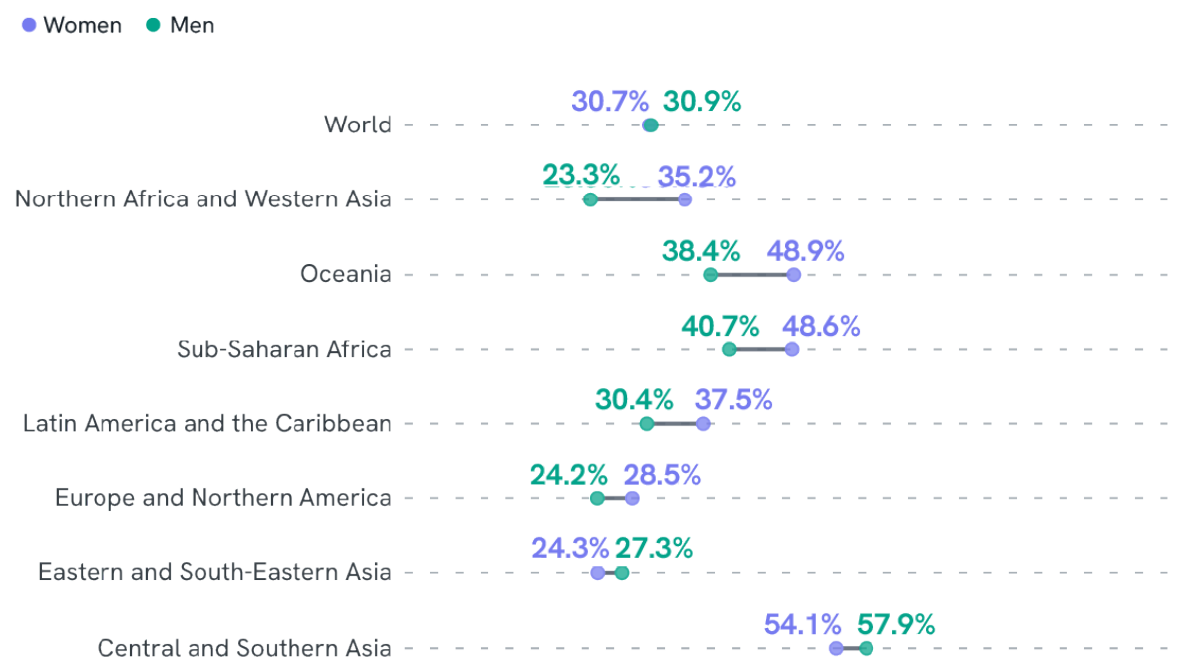
Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates, based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems, data from the World Prison Brief (Institute for Crime & Justice Policy Research) and national sources reviewed by Member States

There is no global gender gap in pre-trial detention, but notable regional gender differences exist

Globally, women and men were equally likely to be held in pre-trial detention, with around one third of detainees in both groups awaiting trial or sentencing. This share has remained largely unchanged since 2015. However, beneath this global average, important regional differences emerge. In Northern Africa and Western Asia, 35 per cent of women detainees were held unsentenced, compared with 23 per cent of men. A similar pattern was observed in Oceania, where nearly half of women detainees (49 per cent) were unsentenced, compared with 38 per cent of men.

Figure 20: Unsented prisoners as a proportion of the overall prison population, by sex and region (2024)



Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems, data from the World Prison Brief (Institute for Crime & Justice Policy Research) and national sources reviewed by Member States

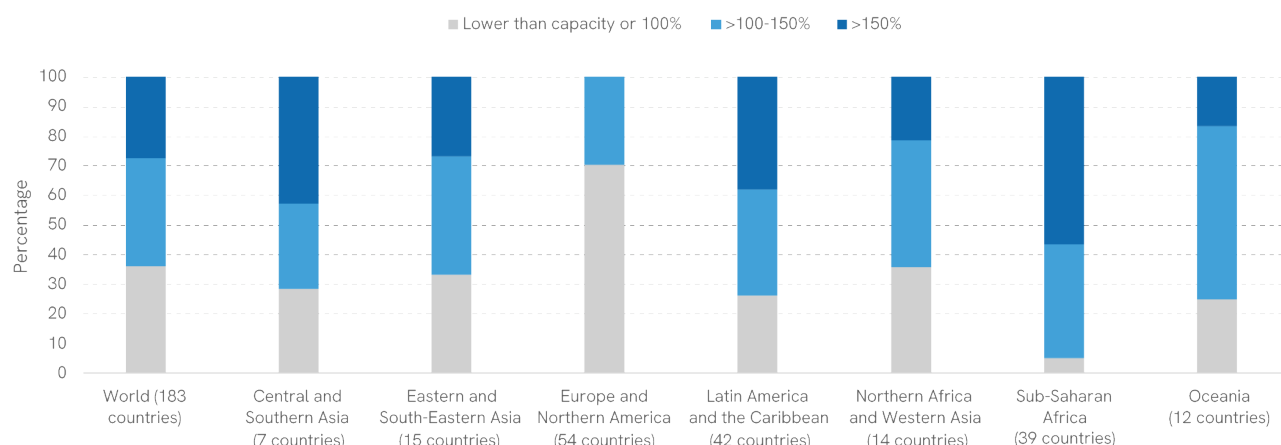
High levels of pre-trial detention also place considerable pressure on prison systems. In 2024, nearly two thirds of countries with available data reported prison populations exceeding their official prison capacity, while more than one quarter exceeded 150 per cent of intended capacity. Overcrowding can undermine human rights, restrict access to health care, and legal services, and has well-documented consequences for health¹¹ and mortality.¹² These findings highlight the importance of implementing the United Nations Standard Minimum Rules for the Treatment of Prisoners (the Nelson Mandela Rules)¹³, including measures to reduce unnecessary pre-trial detention and expand alternatives to imprisonment.

11 Møller, L., Gatherer, A., & Jürgens, R. 2016. Health in prisons: A WHO guide to the essentials in prison health. World Health Organization Regional Office for Europe.

12 Fazel, S., Ramesh, T., Hawton, K. 2017. Suicide in prisons: An international study of prevalence and contributory factors. *The Lancet Public Health*, 2(3), e120-e126; Wolff, N., Jing Shi, J., & Bachman, R. 2008. The impact of prison crowding on inmate violence. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency*, 45(2), 200-220.

13 UN. 2015. A/RES/70/175. Resolution 70/172. United Nations Standard Minimum Rules for the Treatment of Prisoners (the Nelson Mandela Rules).

Figure 21: Percentage of countries where prisoners outnumber the prison capacity (2024 or latest year available)



Source: UNODC

Note: Estimates based on responses to the United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems, data from the World Prison Brief (Institute for Crime & Justice Policy Research) and national sources reviewed by Member States. Prison overcrowding occurs when the number of prisoners in a country exceeds the official prison capacity.

SDG INDICATOR 16.4.1 – ILLICIT FINANCIAL FLOWS

Illicit financial flows continue to erode the rule of law and divert billions of dollars away from sustainable development

Illicit financial flows (IFFs)¹⁴ have significant economic and institutional impacts. Generated through activities such as the trade in illicit goods and illicit tax and commercial practices, IFFs can be detrimental both as outflows from a country and as inflows into one. By facilitating corruption, organized crime and terrorism, they can weaken state institutions and undermine justice, the rule of law, investment, and sustainable development. Their impacts may be particularly severe in countries facing political instability, weak institutions, and high levels of corruption. Curbing IFFs could help preserve domestic resources, strengthen public revenues, and serve as a vital source of funding for sustainable development initiatives and help bridge the financing gap.¹⁵

Despite growing international attention, measuring illicit financial flows remains a major challenge. Official data on IFFs remain limited, but the first systematic studies suggest that the scale of the problem ranges from hundreds of millions to billions of dollars annually. To date, official estimates of crime-related IFFs have been produced for nine countries.¹⁶ For example, in Myanmar, the opiates economy generated an estimated US\$564 million to US\$974 million in potential inwards IFFs in 2025,

¹⁴ Illicit financial flows (IFFs) are defined as “flows that are illicit in origin, transfer or use, that reflect an exchange of value and that cross country borders.” See [Conceptual Framework for the Statistical Measurement of Illicit Financial Flows](#), prepared by United Nations Conference on Trade and Development and United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (2020).

¹⁵ [Financing for Sustainable Development Report 2021](#), Inter-agency Task Force on Financing for Development (United Nations publication, 2021).

¹⁶ [UNODC, Opiates and Methamphetamine Trafficking on the Balkan Route: Drug Flows, Illicit Incomes and Illicit Financial Flows](#) (United Nations Publication, 2025).



equivalent to 0.8 to 1.3 per cent of the GDP.¹⁷ Along the Balkan drug trafficking route, proceeds from trafficking in opiates and methamphetamine were estimated to generate between US\$3.4 billion and US\$6.9 billion annually between 2019 and 2022.¹⁸

The first official estimates of tax and commercial IFFs also point to substantial losses. Pilot studies in selected African countries¹⁹ indicate that trade-related IFFs account for between 5 and 30 per cent of the official value of goods trade. Burkina Faso reported estimated annual outflows of US\$319 million from a selected basket of exported commodities including mineral oils, gold, beverages, and oil seeds and fruits (notably mangoes). Ghana recorded several billions in cumulative IFFs between 2013 and 2023, with 91 per cent linked to exports in gold, cocoa, and oil. In Gabon, trade-misinvoicing IFFs are concentrated in oil, timber, and mining exports (notably manganese), with a declining trend in timber and manganese, while remaining persistently high for oil. In Zambia, IFFs are concentrated in copper and gold, with some exports declared at prices below their market value. This allows profits to be shifted abroad, reducing domestic tax base and revenue collection. On the other hand, imports of petroleum, fertilizer and sulphur appear consistently invoiced at prices above their market value, suggesting possible irregularities in procurement contracts. Manufactured goods are also frequently under-declared, pointing to routine duty evasion and widespread smuggling practices.

Effective responses require a whole-of-government approach that combines stronger legal and regulatory frameworks, enhanced tax transparency, and robust enforcement mechanisms targeting trade misinvoicing, transfer pricing abuse, cross-border corruption and transnational organized crime. Equally important is enhanced cooperation and information exchange among domestic agencies, such as tax authorities, customs, law enforcement agencies, financial intelligence units, as well as across borders through international frameworks, to detect, prevent, and recover illicit funds more effectively.

¹⁷ UNODC, *Myanmar Opium Survey 2025: Cultivation, Production and Implications* (United Nations publication, 2025).

¹⁸ UNODC, *Opiates and Methamphetamine Trafficking on the Balkan Route: Drug Flows, Illicit Incomes and Illicit Financial Flows* (United Nations Publication, 2025).

¹⁹ Pilot studies were undertaken on 23 countries globally, with UN support prioritized in developing countries. 14 countries of Africa led the way on the measurement of tax and commercial IFFs, and only a handful are reporting data for SDGs. More details are available at: <https://unctad.org/statistics/illicit-financial-flows>

Ghana turns illicit financial flows data into policy action

The first measurement studies on IFFs are now being translated directly into informed policy action. For example, the Ghana Revenue Authority and Ministry of Finance strengthened transfer pricing enforcement and customs valuation controls, contributing to a documented 78 per cent reduction in IFFs from 2019 to 2023.²⁰ The analysis also highlighted uneven enforcement across firms, a finding now reflected in ongoing tax administration reforms. Ghana is institutionalizing this work within its national statistical and planning systems, expanding coverage to additional commodity exports and linking regular public reporting on IFFs to domestic revenue performance, demonstrating how sustained investment in data systems, supported by internationally agreed methods, technical training and tools, can turn data into a practical tool for domestic resource mobilization and effective and targeted policy response.

KEY NUMBERS

78%

Reduction in illicit financial flows, 2019-2023

²⁰ As reported by the Ghana National Development Planning Commission.



SDG INDICATOR 16.4.2 – ILLICIT FIREARMS FLOWS

Less than half of seized firearms are successfully traced, limiting efforts to reduce illicit arms flows globally

Tracing firearms, the process of identifying the illicit origin of seized, found, and surrendered arms, is a critical tool for combating illicit arms trafficking. Successful tracing helps authorities identify trafficking routes, detect diversion points, uncover criminal networks and prevent firearms from being used in future crimes. Without effective tracing, efforts to reduce illicit arms flows and strengthen public security are significantly undermined.

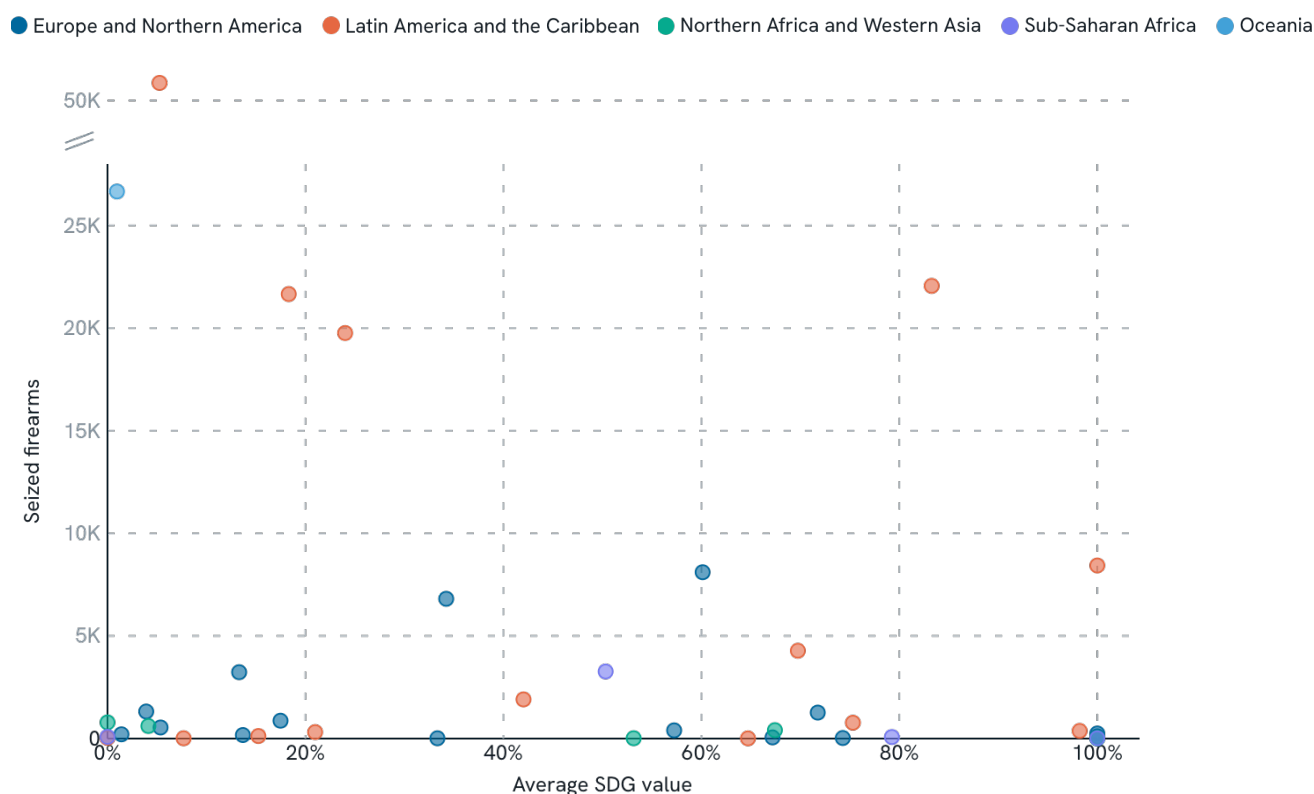
Tracing has become increasingly challenging. To conceal the origin of firearms, criminal groups increasingly rely on illicit manufacturing methods, including counterfeit production, 3D printing, and artisanal manufacture as well as the modification of non-lethal/less-lethal weapons (e.g. gas and blank firing, alarm or signal weapons) into firearms, often accompanied by the alteration and falsification of original markings. In conflict settings, the diversion of weapons through battlefield capture further complicates tracing efforts.

Fragmented and weak record-keeping systems and limited information sharing at the national and international levels can also slow investigations and reduce tracing success.

Only 46 per cent of seized firearms are successfully traced

Between 2016 and 2024, countries with available data successfully traced, on average, only 46 per cent of seized firearms. Tracing rates varied considerably across countries, regions, and reporting years, reflecting differences in national tracing capacities, the volume of firearms seized, and the complexity of establishing the illicit origin of individual firearms. Robust marking and record-keeping systems constitute key measures for effective tracing. Between 2020 and 2021, national authorities marked on average 63 per cent and recorded 75 per cent of the weapons seized, found, and surrendered.²¹ This represented a notable improvement from 2018–2019, when only an average of 14 per cent of collected weapons were marked and 58 per cent were recorded. Despite this progress, significant gaps remain in many countries, limiting the ability of authorities to trace weapons successfully and identify trafficking networks.

Figure 22: Firearm tracing success relative to average seizure volumes, by country (2016–2024)



Source : UNODC

Note: Illicit Arms Flow Questionnaire (IAFQ). Simple averages calculated based on data submitted by 40 Member States.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

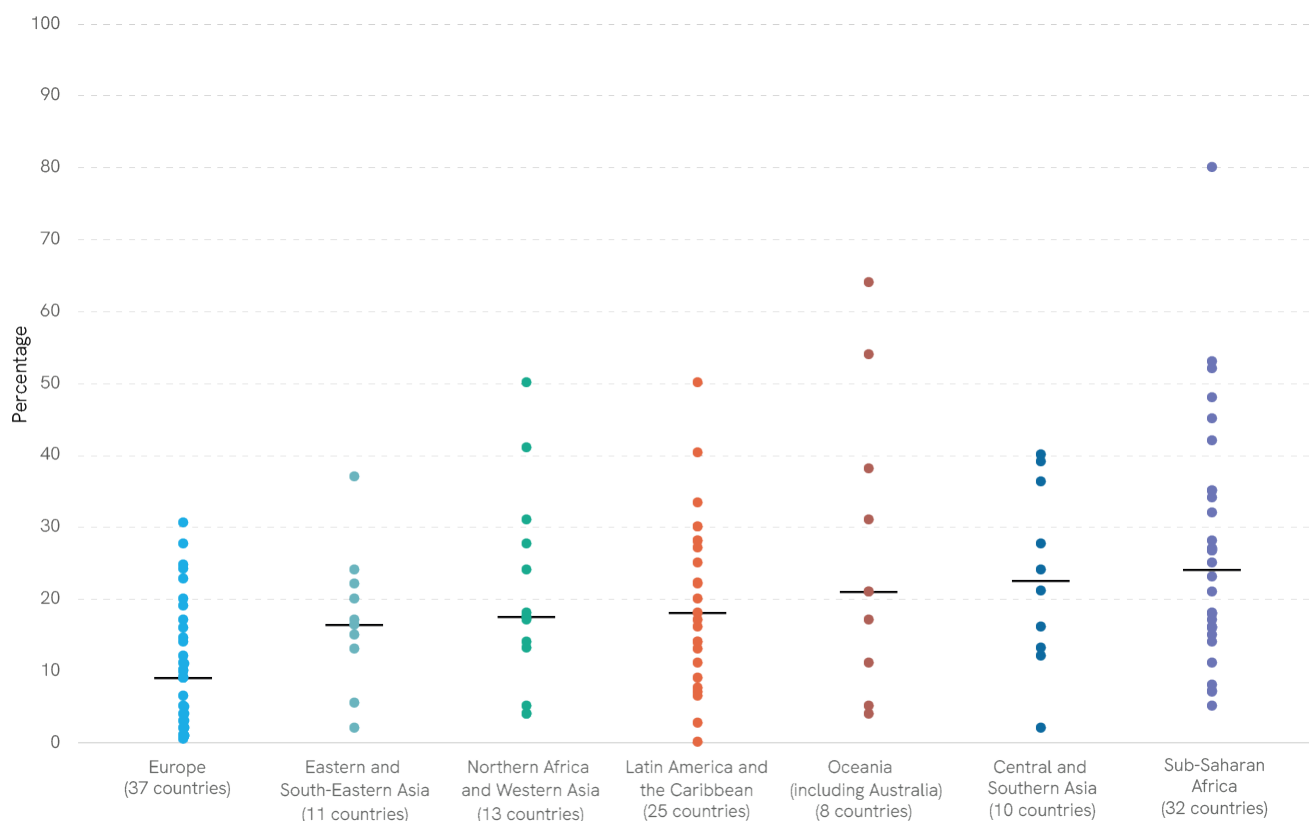
Data availability remains a major challenge. Even in regions with relatively strong reporting systems, such as Europe and Northern America, and Latin America and the Caribbean, more than half of reporting countries recorded tracing rates below the global average of 46 per cent. Continued investment in marking, record-keeping, and tracing systems, together with stronger national and international information-sharing mechanisms, will be essential for improving tracing outcomes, identifying diversion patterns, and reducing illicit arms flows.

²¹ Simple average based on data from 35 Member States reported through the 2022 national reports on the implementation of the UN Programme of Action on small arms and light weapons.

Bribery remains widespread, with large differences across regions

Bribery can undermine trust in public institutions, distort access to public services, and weaken confidence that laws are applied fairly. Among the 139 countries and territories with available data, the median prevalence of bribery was approximately 17 per cent.²² A comparison of the earliest available data point in the period 2010–2017 with the latest available data point in the period 2018–2025 among the 63 countries with data from both periods, reveals a relatively stable global trend in the prevalence of bribery among the general population. However, this global picture masks large differences across regions. The highest median prevalence was recorded in Sub-Saharan Africa (24 per cent) and Central and Southern Asia (22.5 per cent), while Europe and Northern America recorded the lowest median prevalence (9 per cent).

Figure 23: Proportion of population that experienced bribery when in contact with public officials in the previous 12 months, by region (2024 or latest year available since 2015)



Source: UNODC, Global Corruption Barometer

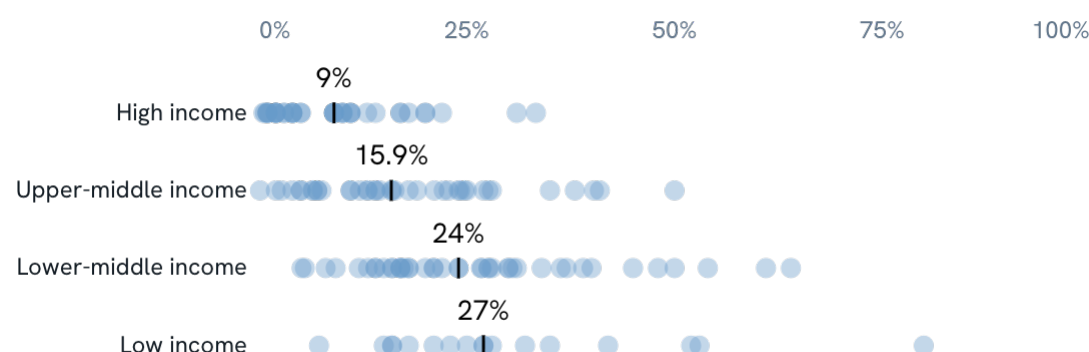
Note: Estimates based on responses to the UNODC United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems (UN-CTS) and Global Corruption Barometer. Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence. The median represents the middle value, with half of observations above and half below it.

²² In other words, in half of the countries with available data, at least 17 per cent of people who had contact with a public official during the previous 12 months either paid a bribe or were asked to pay one.

Bribery is more prevalent in low-income countries, but important differences exist within income groups

Considerable variation also exists within regions, highlighting that experiences of bribery are not shaped by geography alone. Bribery was most prevalent in low-income countries, where the median prevalence reached 27 per cent, compared with 9 per cent in high-income countries. Nevertheless, substantial variation exists within each income group, suggesting that economic development alone does not determine corruption risks. The quality of governance, institutional integrity, and the effectiveness of anti-corruption measures also play an important role.

Figure 24: Proportion of population that experienced bribery when in contact with public officials in the previous 12 months, by country income level (2024 or latest year available since 2015)



Source: UNODC, Global Corruption Barometer

Note: Estimates based on responses to the UNODC United Nations Survey of Crime Trends and Operations of Criminal Justice Systems (UN-CTS) and Global Corruption Barometer. Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence. The median represents the middle value, with half of observations above and half below it.

Sex-disaggregated data remain limited, with information available for only 23 countries between 2010 and 2024. Across these countries, the median prevalence of bribery was 12 per cent among women, compared with 17 per cent among men.

SDG INDICATOR 16.5.2 - BRIBERY OF BUSINESSES

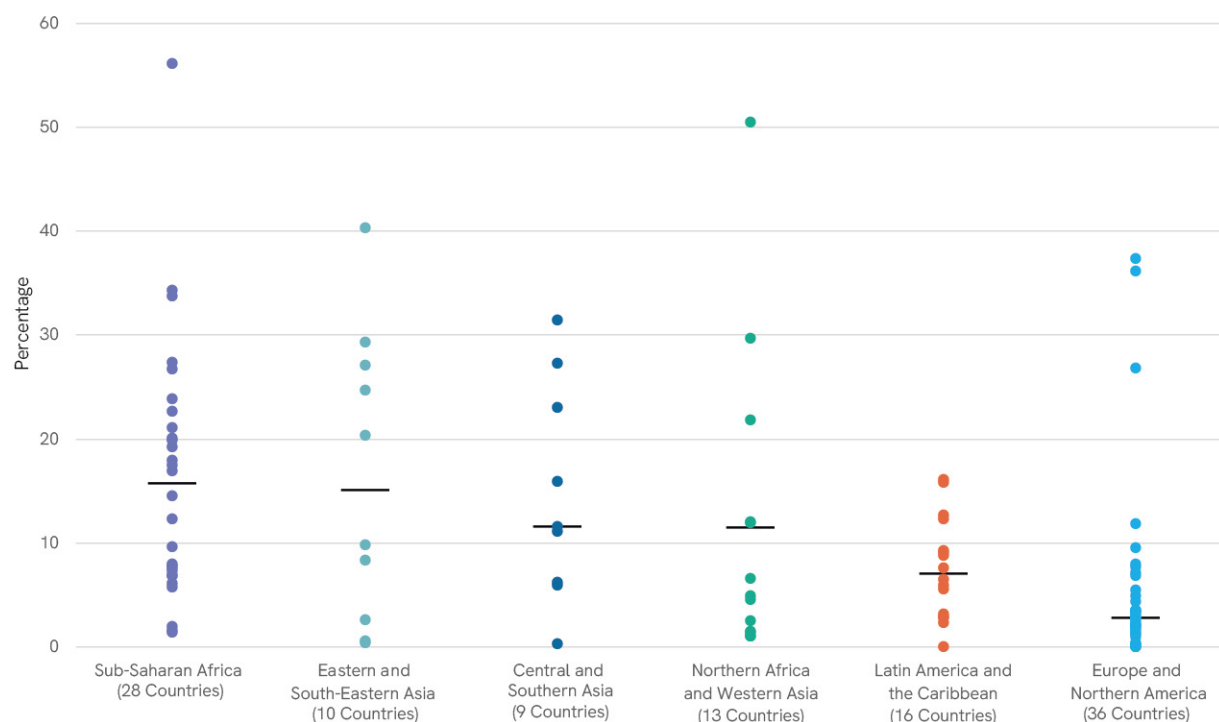
Businesses also continue to face bribery when interacting with public officials

Corruption can increase the cost of doing business, distort competition and discourage investment. Available evidence suggests that bribery is generally less common among businesses than among individuals when interacting with public officials. However, these findings should be interpreted with caution as businesses may be less willing to disclose bribery experiences due to concerns about potential legal, financial, or reputational consequences. As a result, available estimates are likely to represent a lower bound of the true extent of business bribery.

Business bribery varies widely across regions and income groups

The prevalence of bribery among businesses varies considerably across regions. Sub-Saharan Africa and Eastern and South-Eastern Asia recorded the highest median levels of business bribery, while Europe and Northern America recorded the lowest.

Figure 25: Proportion of businesses that experienced bribery by region (2024 or latest available year since-2015)



Source: World Bank Enterprise Surveys.

Note: Each dot represents a country. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence. These estimates are not directly comparable to the prevalence of bribery among the population in those regions as they are based on different sets of countries with available data in each region.

A similar pattern emerges across income groups. Businesses operating in low-income countries reported the highest median prevalence of bribery at 18.6 per cent, compared with 2.4 per cent in high-income countries. These differences suggest that businesses operating in lower-income settings are more likely to encounter bribery when dealing with public officials.

Business bribery has declined over time

Available trend data in a more limited set of countries suggest a moderate decline in business bribery across all income groups between 2010–2016 and 2017–2024. The largest improvements were observed in low-income countries, where the median prevalence fell from 21.0 per cent to 12.3 per cent, and in lower-middle-income countries, where it declined from 21.75 per cent to 13.9 per cent. Although these trends point to gradual progress and suggest that efforts towards transparent governance and reducing corruption are paying off globally, bribery continues to affect businesses in many countries.

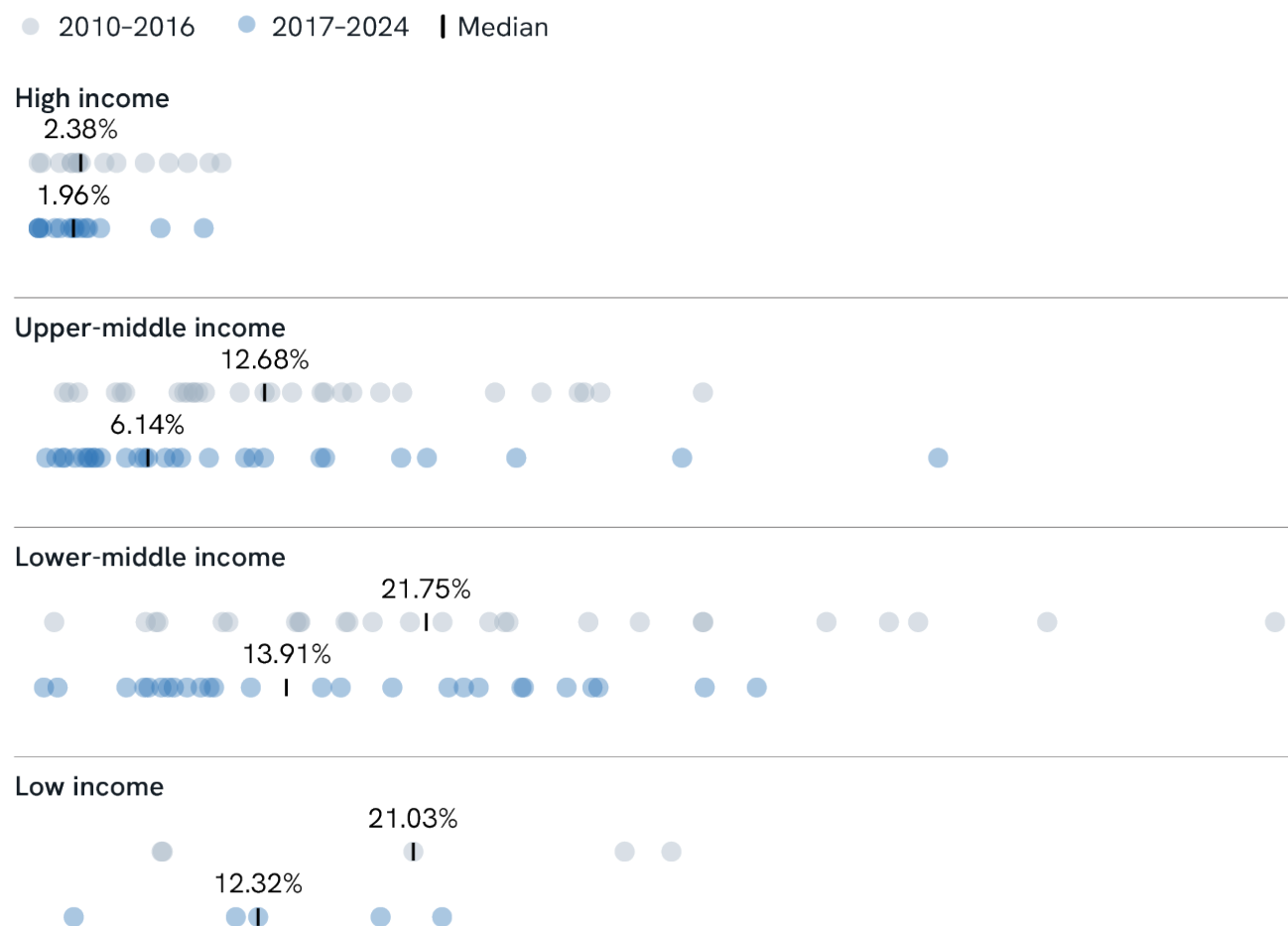
Business and individual bribery tend to occur together

Countries reporting higher levels of bribery affecting businesses also tend to report higher levels of bribery experienced by individuals.²³ This suggests that corruption affecting businesses and households often reflects the same underlying governance and accountability challenges.

37



Figure 26: Proportion of businesses that experienced bribery by income level (2010-2016 and 2017-2024)



Source: World Bank Enterprise Surveys.

Note: Each dot represents a country. Data based on the earliest available year between 2010 and 2016 and latest available year between 2017 and 2024. The horizontal black bars show the median prevalence. Countries classified by income level of 2024.

23 In the sample of 121 countries and territories with at least one data point on population bribery prevalence and one data point on business bribery incidence in the period 2010-2025, the correlation is 0.6 and statistically significant ($p < 0.001$)

Progress had stalled in establishing National Human Rights Institutions compliant with the Paris Principles

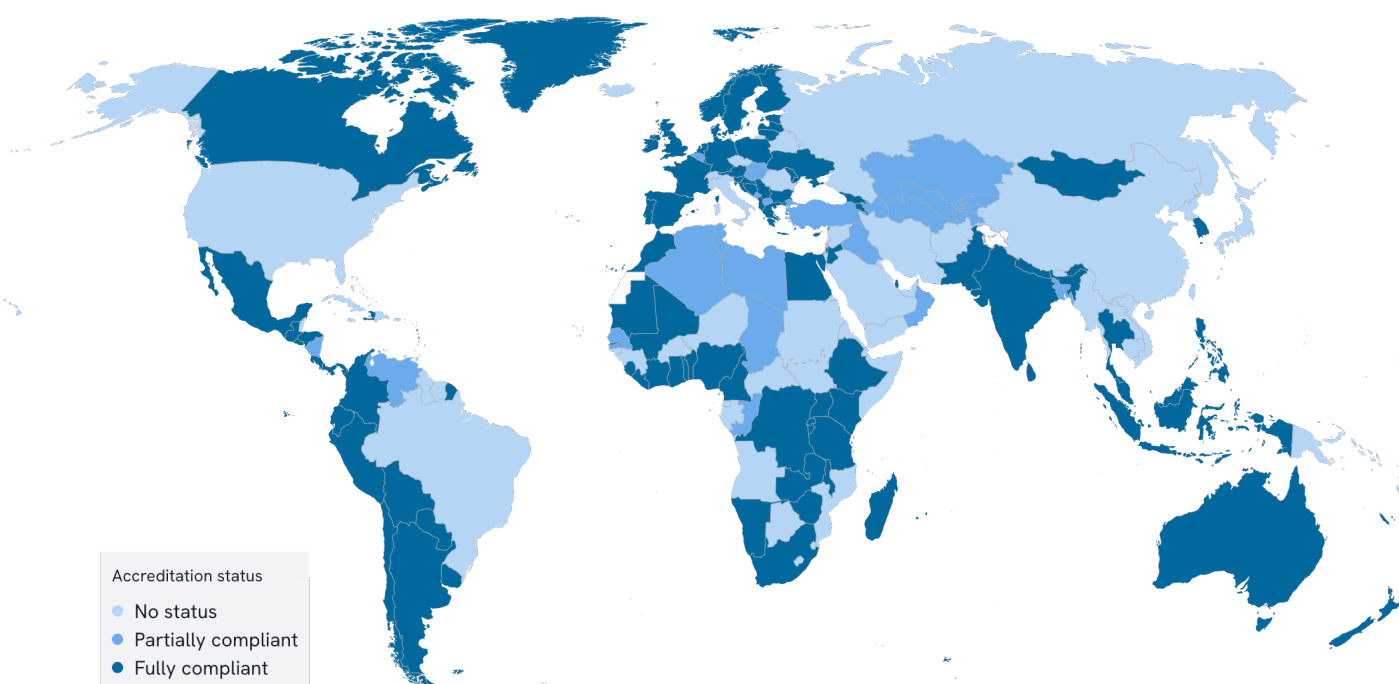
NHRIs play a vital role in protecting human rights, monitoring government action, and providing independent oversight. In 2025, 89 countries had NHRIs that were fully compliant (A status) with the [Paris Principles](#), the internationally agreed standards that define their independence, mandate, effectiveness, and functioning. This represents 46 per cent of UN Member States and observers and covers 55 per cent of the world's population.

The number of fully compliant institutions increased from 70 countries in 2015 to 89 in 2025. However, there was no net increase between 2024 and 2025, indicating that progress has stalled, as gains in some countries were offset by setbacks in others. A further 26 countries had institutions with partial compliance to the Paris Principles (B status).

Progress remains uneven across regions and country groups

Regional patterns differ considerably. Europe and Northern America continue to have the highest share of countries with fully compliant NHRIs (A-status), while Sub-Saharan Africa has recorded the greatest progress since 2015, with more than half of countries now hosting A-status institutions. By contrast, compliance remains lower in Central and Southern Asia and Oceania, while progress in Eastern and South-Eastern Asia has been limited. In 2025, Latin America and the Caribbean recorded a modest improvement in compliance, while Northern Africa and Western Asia experienced a decline.

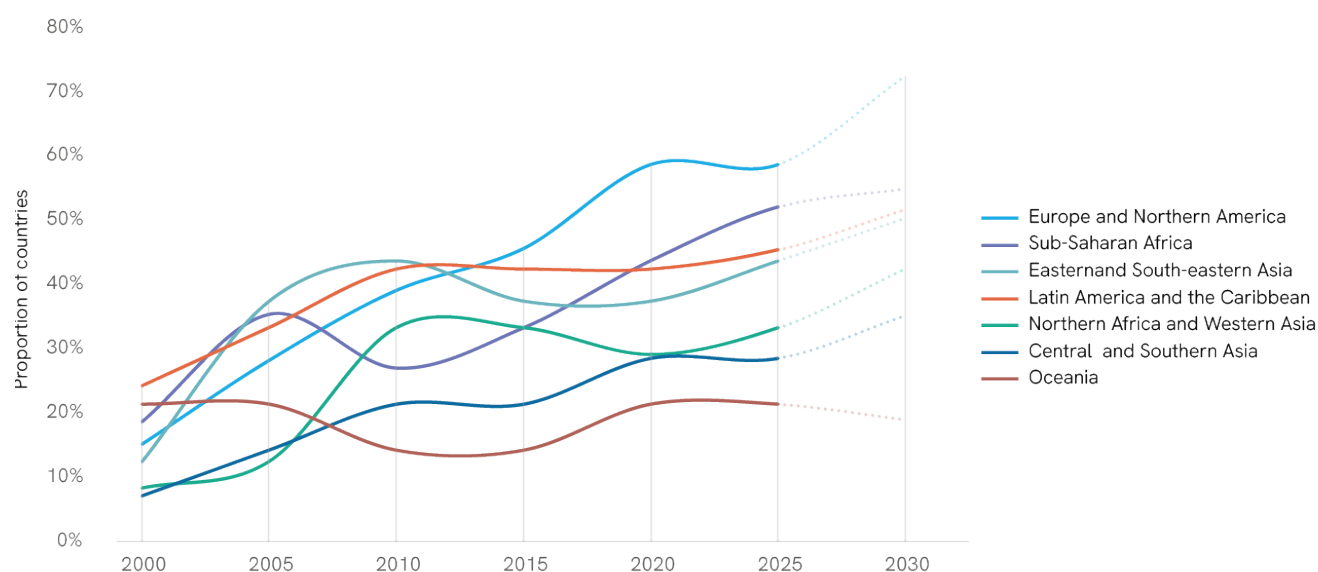
Figure 27: Proportion of countries with independent NHRIs in compliance with the Paris Principles in 2025 (A and B status), by region



Source: OHCHR in collaboration with Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions (GANHRI).

Least Developed Countries and Landlocked Developing Countries have made notable progress since 2015, reaching around 43 to 44 per cent of countries with fully compliant institutions (A-status). Small Island Developing States continue to lag behind, with only about 11 per cent of countries hosting A-status NHRIs.

Figure 28: Proportion of countries with fully compliant NHRIs by region, (2000-2030)



Source: OHCHR in collaboration with Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions (GANHRI).

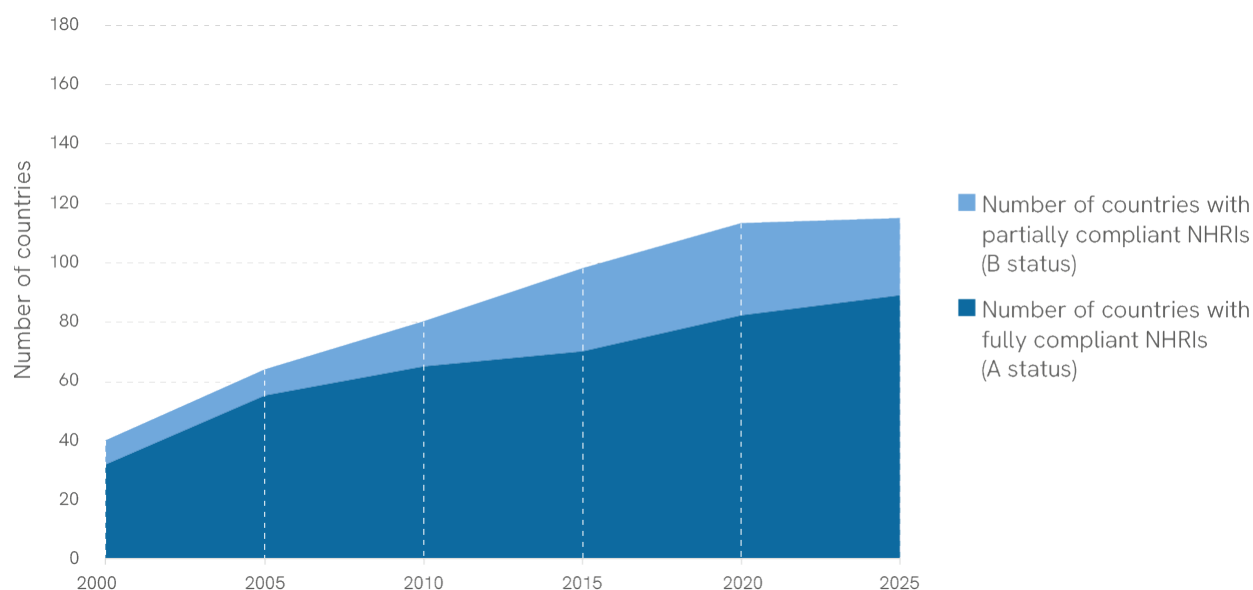
Current progress is too slow to achieve universal coverage

Despite steady long-term gains, progress remains too slow to achieve universal coverage of NHRIs that are fully compliant with the Paris Principles (A status). Since 2015, the number of A status NHRIs has increased by an average of only two countries per year. At this pace, many countries will still lack fully compliant institutions by 2030. Accelerating progress will require not only establishing NHRIs where they do not yet exist, but also strengthening the independence, effectiveness, accessibility, and long-term sustainability of the existing ones.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

This indicator provides an important measure of whether countries have established independent human rights institutions that comply with international standards. However, accreditation status alone does not fully capture how effectively institutions function in practice. Important aspects such as operational independence, resources, accessibility, responsiveness, and impact on human rights outcomes remain difficult to measure systematically. In addition, limited data exists on how NHRIs operate across different country contexts or how they address specific population groups. Without more detailed and regular data on institutional performance, it remains difficult to assess whether formal compliance translates into meaningful protection of human rights.

Figure 29: Number of countries with fully and partially compliant NHRIs, 2000 – 2025



Source: OHCHR in collaboration with Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions (GANHRI).



The role of institutions in ensuring access to justice for all

Taken together, the justice indicators point to a common institutional challenge: ensuring that people can access justice, exercise their rights and receive fair and equal treatment under the law. Disputes are an inevitable part of any society. Injustice is not.

Whether people can obtain redress when their rights are violated depends on institutions that are accessible, impartial, and capable of administering justice, upholding the rule of law, protecting human rights, and ensuring accountability. Effective institutions provide mechanisms through which people can report crimes, resolve disputes, and seek remedies, while safeguarding due process, and ensuring that decisions are guided by law rather than by money, influence or status.

Justice also depends on trust. People are more likely to report crimes, seek redress for grievances, and comply with laws when they

believe institutions will treat them fairly and equally. Independent National Human Rights Institutions play a vital role in this institutional ecosystem by monitoring human rights, promoting accountability, and helping ensure that governments fulfil their obligations under international human rights law. Equally important are institutions that combat corruption and organized crime, investigate financial crime, safeguard due process, and ensure equal access to justice for all.

Building just societies therefore requires more than laws and formal institutions on paper. It requires institutions that people can access, that apply the law fairly, protect rights, and hold both individuals and public authorities accountable. Where these conditions are weak, grievances can remain unresolved, rights unprotected, and trust undermined. Where they are strong, institutions provide the mechanisms through which justice can be realized in practice.



3. Inclusion

Inclusive societies are built on institutions that recognize, represent, and serve all people equally, and that enable everyone to participate meaningfully in public life. Such institutions strengthen trust, social cohesion, and the legitimacy of governance. While inclusion is a broad concept that cannot be fully captured by a single set of indicators, Goal 16 measures several of its most fundamental dimensions.

Inclusion begins at birth, when a child's birth is registered, providing a foundation for legal identity. Without proof of legal identity, people may face barriers to accessing education, health care, social protection, financial services, and legal protection. Significant progress has been made in expanding birth registration over the past decade, but around 150 million children worldwide remain unregistered.

Inclusion also requires that public institutions reflect the diversity of the populations they serve. Countries have made important gains in representation of women in parliaments, public service, and the judiciary. Nevertheless, women remain underrepresented in many leadership and decision-making positions, while many population groups continue to face

barriers to equal representation and opportunity. Equal participation is closely linked to equal treatment. Yet nearly one in five people globally report having experienced discrimination, showing that equal treatment and equal opportunities remain out of reach for many.

Finally, inclusion depends not only on who institutions represent, but also on how people experience them. Governments must deliver accessible, high-quality public services, manage public resources fairly and effectively, and provide meaningful opportunities for people to participate in public decision-making. Yet, satisfaction with public services continues to vary widely across countries, and fewer than half of people globally believe they have a meaningful say in what government does.

Taken together, these indicators reveal whether people are recognized by the state, represented in public institutions, treated fairly regardless of who they are, and able to participate in decisions that affect their lives. Building inclusive societies therefore requires institutions that not only serve people, but also ensure that everyone has a place, a voice, and an equal opportunity to contribute.

Birth registration continues to expand, but 150 million children remain without a legal identity

Birth registration is the first step towards inclusion in society. Establishing a child's legal identity helps protect fundamental rights and enables access to essential services such as health care, education, and social protection.²⁴

Today, nearly eight in ten children under the age of five, more than 500 million children, have had their births registered. This represents significant global progress and an important achievement since 2008, when only six in ten children under five had their births registered. Despite this important global achievement, progress has slowed over the past decade, and an estimated 150 million children remain unregistered.²⁵

There is little evidence of gender inequality in birth registration. Across almost all countries with available data, boys and girls are registered at similar rates. This suggests that the remaining gaps primarily reflect inequalities in access to registration systems rather than differences between girls and boys.

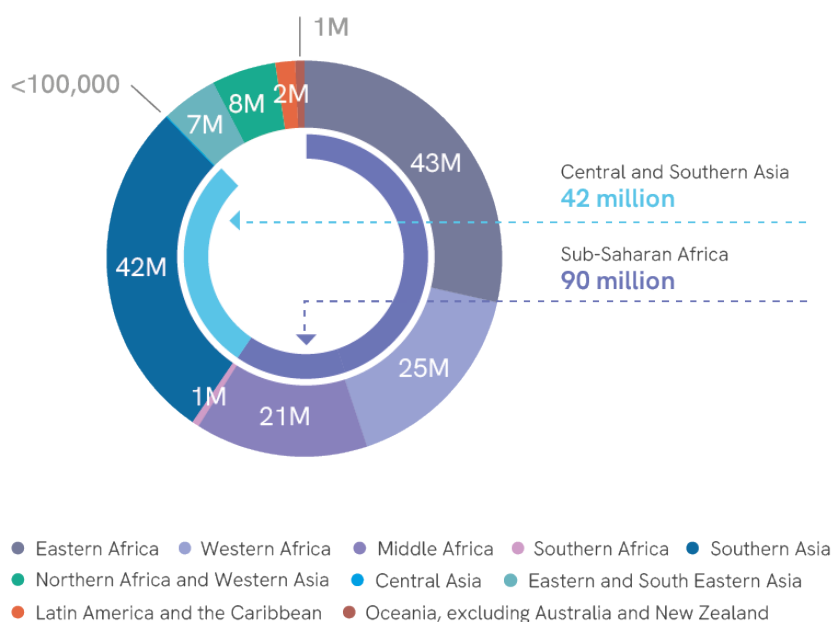
More than half of the world's unregistered children live in Sub-Saharan Africa

The children who remain unregistered are highly concentrated geographically. More than half of all unregistered children, around 90 million, live in Sub-Saharan Africa, making it the region furthest behind from achieving universal birth registration.

Figure 30: Number of children under age 5 whose births are not registered, by region (2014-2023)

Source: UNICEF

Notes: These estimates are based on data collected between 2014 and 2023 for a subset of 173 countries and areas, representing 98 per cent of the global population of children under age 5. Population coverage is above 70 per cent for all SDG regions. In the regions of Europe and Northern America and Australia and New Zealand, 100 per cent of children are estimated to be registered on the basis of civil registration coverage. Data are drawn from the UNICEF global databases, 2024, based on Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys and Demographic and Health Surveys, vital statistics from civil registration systems, censuses, and other nationally representative surveys that use a comparable methodology. These national data are also included in the official global database for SDG indicator 16.9.1.



²⁴ United Nations Children's Fund, [The Right Start in Life: Global levels and trends in birth registration](#). 2024 update, UNICEF, New York, 2024.

²⁵ All estimates on birth registration are from United Nations Children's Fund, [The Right Start in Life: Global levels and trends in birth registration](#). 2024 update, UNICEF, New York, 2024.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

Strong civil registration systems are essential not only for ensuring legal identity but also for producing vital statistics, foundational for achieving sustained development. Much of the recent improvement in global data coverage has resulted from increased investment in household surveys in low- and middle-income countries. Nevertheless, even for those countries with mechanisms in place for registering births through civil registration systems, the systematic recording of births remains a serious challenge.²⁶ Continued investment in civil registration and vital statistics systems remains essential for achieving universal birth registration and strengthening inclusive governance.



SDG INDICATOR 16.7.1 (A) – REPRESENTATION IN THE LEGISLATURE

Women hold only one in four parliamentary seats, while only one in five Members of Parliaments are under 40

As societies confront increasingly complex challenges from climate change and conflict to economic insecurity and technological change, it becomes increasingly important that political decision making reflects the diversity of the populations it serves. Women and younger representatives, for example, bring unique lived experiences and different policy priorities than other population groups, helping to broaden parliamentary debate and strengthen the responsiveness of public policy.^{27,28,29,30,31}

Despite steady progress over the past decade, parliaments remain far from reflecting the populations they represent. As of 2026, women held 27.5 per cent of parliamentary seats globally, a modest increase from 27.2 per cent in 2025. Representation remains even lower in parliamentary leadership, where women accounted for 19.9 per cent of Speakers of Parliament in 2026, a decline of 3.8 percentage points from the previous year.³² These figures highlight the persistent barriers women continue to face in accessing the highest levels of political leadership.

26 Ibid.

27 Young leaders tend to have different priorities from their older counterparts, typically leaning towards social spending related to their cohort's long-term future, such as climate change, and women leaders often favor investments on education, childcare, and influence gender-sensitive policy discussions in Parliaments.

28 Dovi, Suzanne (2018). "Political Representation". In: The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. Ed. by Edward N. Zalta. Fall 2018. Metaphysics Research Lab, Stanford University.

29 Dahis, R., de las Heras, I., & Saavedra, S. (2024). Young politicians and long-term policy. Available at SSRN 4265051.

30 Clots-Figueras, I. (2011). Women in politics: Evidence from the Indian States. *Journal of public Economics*, 95(7-8), 664-690.

31 Funk, K. D., Morales, L., & Taylor-Robinson, M. M. (2017). The impact of committee composition and agendas on women's participation: Evidence from a legislature with near numerical equality. *Politics & Gender*, 13(2), 253-275.

32 IPU (2026), [Women in Politics: 2026](#).

Young people remain underrepresented in political decision-making

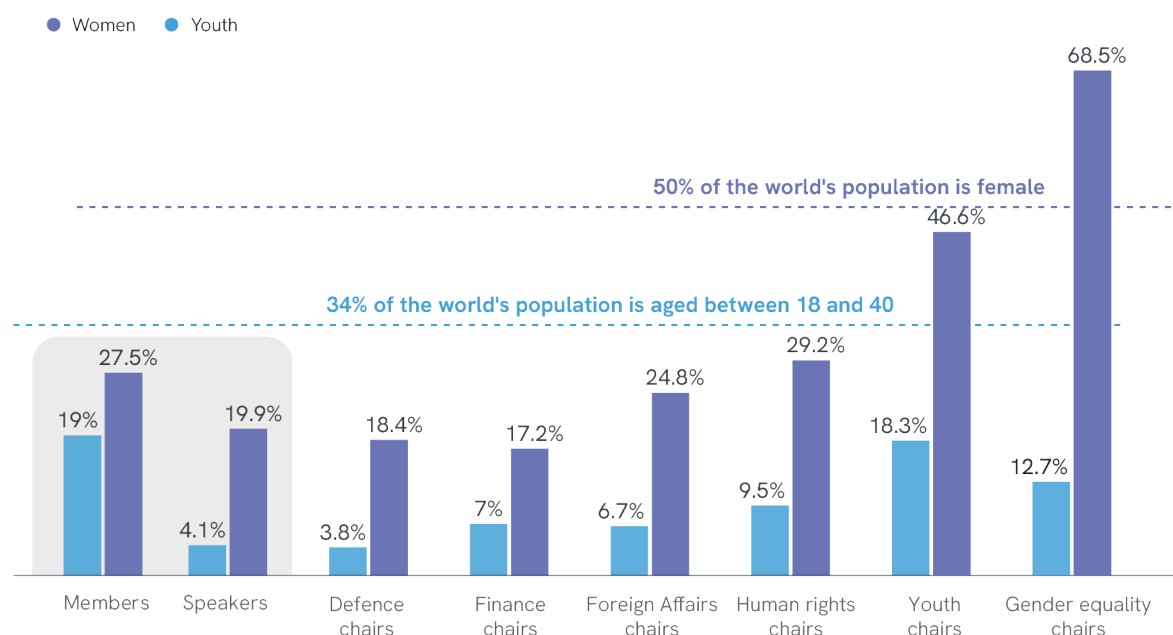
Age gaps in representation are even more pronounced. While people aged 18 to 40 account for around one third of the world's adult population, they represent only 19 per cent of parliamentarians globally. Although this is an important improvement from 12.9 per cent in 2014, progress has slowed considerably in recent years, with only minimal gains since 2023.³³

Representation among the youngest parliamentarians has stagnated entirely. In 2026, just 2.8 per cent of Members of Parliament were aged 30 years or younger, unchanged since 2023, although twice the level observed in 2014 (1.4 per cent)³⁴. Young people are also largely absent from parliamentary leadership. Only 11 Speakers worldwide are aged 40 or younger.

Progress among younger generations offers some grounds for optimism

Younger generations of parliamentarians are, however, considerably more gender balanced than older ones. Women account for 43.5 per cent of all MPs aged 30 years or younger and 36.2 per cent of those aged 40 years or younger. These patterns suggest that gender balance in parliaments may continue to improve as younger cohorts enter political office.

Figure 31: Women and young MPs remain underrepresented in parliamentary leadership (as of January 2026)



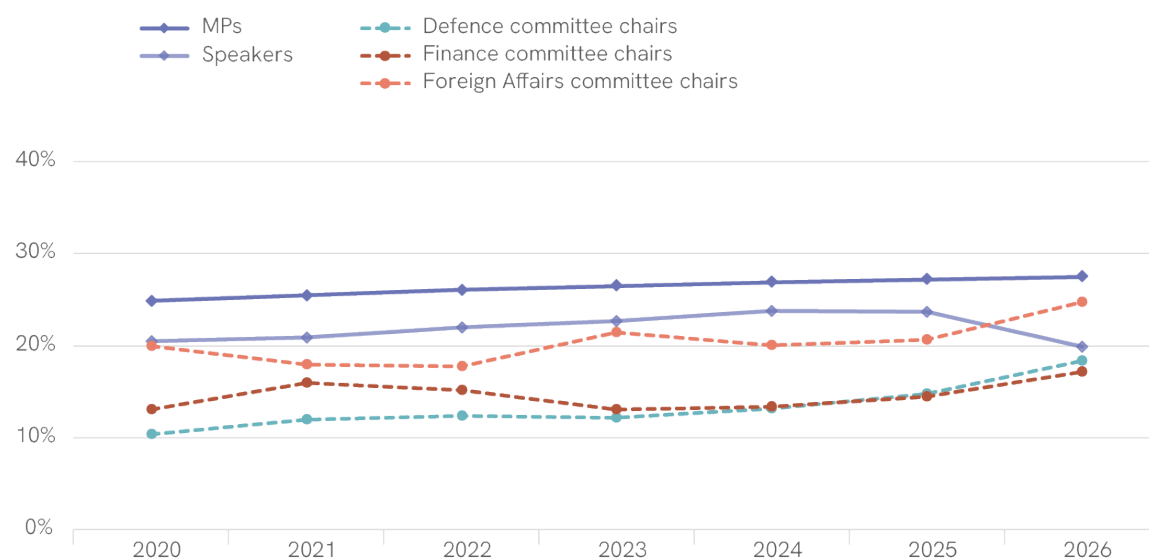
Source: Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU).

Note: Data as of 1 January 2026.

³³ The proportion of women in the leadership of core policy committees has shown signs of progress, with the share of parliamentary chair positions held by women rising by 4.1, 3.6 and 2.7 percentage points for foreign affairs, defense and finance committees, respectively

³⁴ Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU), Parline database on national parliaments, "[MPs aged 30 years or under](#)"

Figure 32: Women representation in parliaments and committees (as of January 2026)



Source: Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU)

Note: Data as of 1 January 2026.

Regional progress differs substantially. The Americas lead in both women's and youth representation, with women holding 35.6 per cent of parliamentary seats and MPs aged 40 or younger accounting for 23.5 per cent of members. By contrast, women hold only 16.2 per cent of seats in the Middle East and North Africa, while the Pacific records the lowest levels of youth representation, with MPs aged 30 or younger accounting for just 2.0 per cent of parliamentarians and those aged 40 or younger only 12.0 per cent.

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

Indicator 16.7.1(a) measures the representation of women and young people in national parliaments. However, inclusive representation extends beyond age and sex. Legislatures should also reflect the diversity of persons with disabilities, Indigenous Peoples, ethnic minorities and other population groups. Data on these dimensions remain limited because of differences in legal frameworks, privacy protections, self-identification practices, and parliamentary reporting systems. Expanding the availability of such data would enable a more comprehensive assessment of whether legislatures truly reflect the societies they serve.



Advancing women's representation in benin's national assembly

Over the past decade, data on the composition of Benin's National Assembly provided a critical evidence base for efforts to increase women's representation in parliament. In 2015, women held just 7.2 per cent of parliamentary seats, well below the West African average of 12.8 per cent recorded at the beginning of 2016.³⁵ Evidence underscoring the persistent gender gap helped elevate the issue on the national political agenda, leading to constitutional and electoral reforms to increase women's participation

In 2018, the National Assembly together with IPU convened a national conference bringing together parliamentarians, government representatives, political parties and civil society to examine the evidence and explore measures to improve women's representation.

These discussions led to legal reforms adopted in 2019, reserving 24 parliamentary seats for women. This resulted in a sharp increase in women's representation from 7.2 per cent in 2015 to 25.7 per cent in 2026.³⁶ Continued commitment by public authorities to empower women MPs supported efforts for capacity-building, advocacy initiatives, and national campaigns encouraging women's political participation. Ahead of the 2026 elections, women MPs engaged political parties and other stakeholders to encourage greater inclusion of women on candidate lists, leading to political parties nominating women beyond the minimum quota requirements, setting the stage for lasting progress toward a more representative legislature.

Benin's experience illustrates how consistent monitoring and data on legislative representation can help identify exclusion, catalyse national-level policy change, and support more inclusive decision-making.

KEY NUMBERS

7.2%

Women in parliament in 2015

25.7%

Women in parliament in 2026

³⁵ https://data.ipu.org/women-averages/?date_month=1&date_year=2016

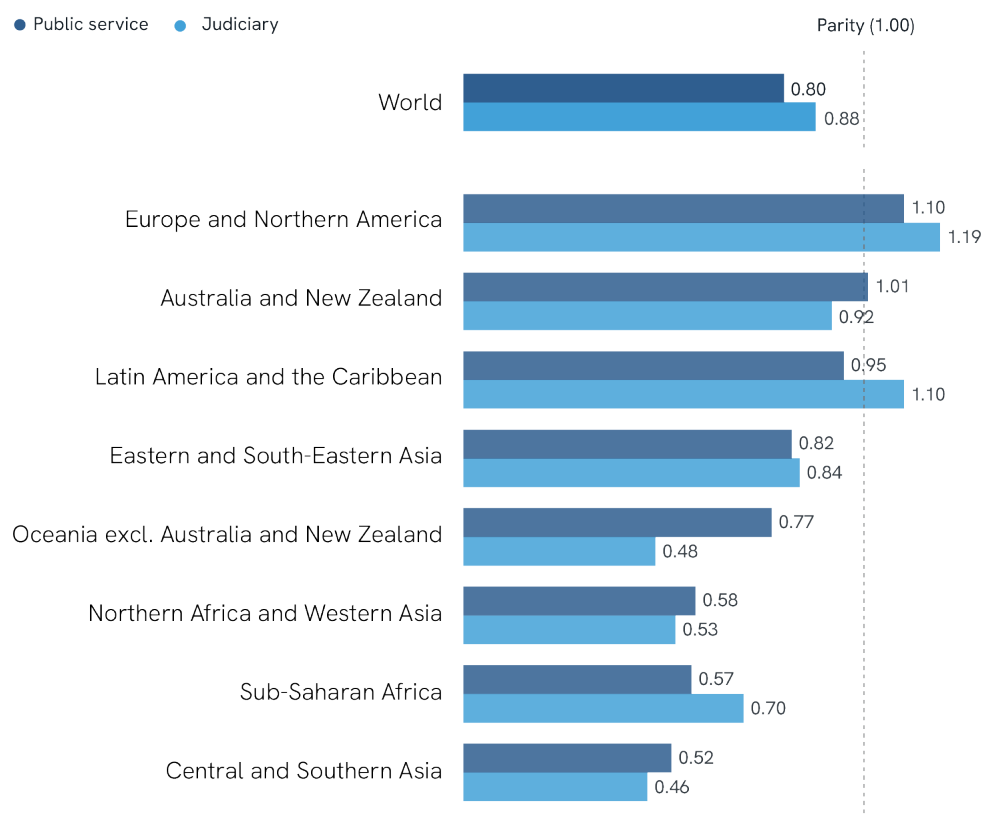
³⁶ <https://data.ipu.org/parliament/BJ/BJ-LC01/data-on-women/>

SDG INDICATOR 16.7.1 (B) AND (C) - REPRESENTATION IN PUBLIC SERVICE INSTITUTIONS AND THE JUDICIARY

Women remain underrepresented in leadership in the public service and judiciary despite broader gains in representation

Women's representation in the public service and the judiciary has improved across many countries, yet this progress has not consistently translated into equal representation. Globally, women remain underrepresented relative to their share of the population in both the public service and the judiciary, with representation ratios of 0.80 and 0.88, respectively, compared with parity at 1.00. Put simply, a ratio of 0.80 means that women have achieved only 80 per cent of the representation they would have if their share in public institutions matched their share of the population.

Figure 33: Ratio of women's representation in the public service and the judiciary relative to their share of the working age population, by region (2025 or latest year available)



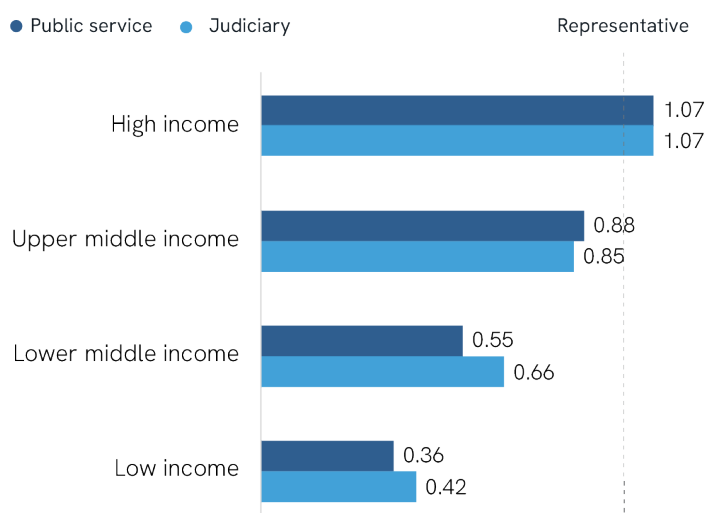
Source: UNDP, [Women in the Judiciary Global Dashboard](#)

Note: SDG indicator 16.7.1 is based on the ratio between the share of a specific population group in parliament (a), public service (b), and judiciary (c), and the share of the same group in the population. A value of 1 indicates parity, while a value under 1 indicates underrepresentation and over 1 indicates overrepresentation. Estimates are derived based on 155 countries and territories for the public service institutions and 131 countries and territories for the judiciary using the latest available data in the period 2015-2025. Previously published estimates were based on 155 countries for public service and 106 countries for the judiciary. Regional estimates for 16.7.1b and 16.7.1c are based on the following number of countries respectively: Europe and Northern America (43 and 45), Latin America and the Caribbean (19 and 19), Eastern and South-Eastern Asia (15 and 5), Sub-Saharan Africa (36 and 24), Oceania including Australia and New Zealand (14 and 10), Northern Africa and Western Asia (16 and 20), Central and Southern Asia (12 and 7).

Recent advances in data collection, including through the [Women in the Judiciary Global Dashboard](#), provide new evidence on how representation is distributed within institutions rather than simply across them in a group of primarily high- and middle-income countries. While women are often well represented, and in some cases overrepresented, in entry-level and administrative roles, their representation declines at higher levels of decision-making. Similar patterns are observed across judicial systems, where women tend to be better represented in lower courts than in supreme or constitutional courts.

Progress also remains uneven across regions and income groups. Countries that have achieved or approached parity are concentrated primarily among high-income countries, while many middle- and low-income countries continue to lag.

Figure 34: Ratio of women's representation in public service and the judiciary relative to their share of the working age population, by income (2025 or latest year available)



Source: UNDP, [Women in the Judiciary Global Dashboard](#)

Note: SDG indicator 16.7.1 is based on the ratio between the share of a specific population group in parliament (a), public service (b), and judiciary (c), and the share of the same group in the population. A value of 1 indicates parity, while a value under 1 indicates underrepresentation and over 1 indicates overrepresentation. Estimates are derived based on 155 countries and territories for the public service institutions and 131 countries and territories for the judiciary using the latest available data in the period 2015-2025. Previously published estimates were based on 155 countries for public service and 105 countries for judiciary. Estimates by countries income level for 16.7.1b and 16.7.1c are based on the following number of countries respectively: High income (54 and 61), Upper middle income (39 and 34), Lower middle income (40 and 25), Low income (26 and 11).

The evidence suggests that achieving inclusive governance requires more than improving overall representation. It must also focus on which level within institutions women are represented. Ensuring that women have equal opportunities to advance into leadership and decision-making roles is therefore an important dimension of achieving representative and inclusive institutions.

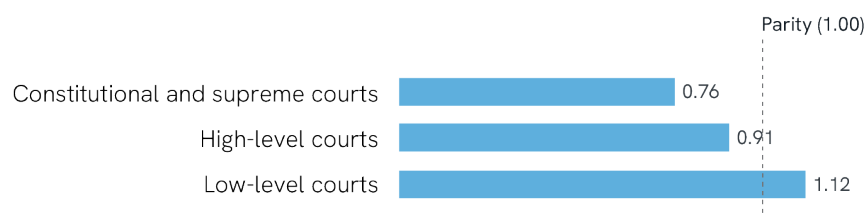
Figure 35: Ratio of women's representation in public service relative to their share of the working age population, by occupation (2025 or latest data available)



Source: UNDP

Note: SDG indicator 16.7.1 is based on the ratio between the share of a specific population group in parliament (a), public service (b), and judiciary (c), and the share of the same group in the population. A value of 1 indicates parity, while a value under 1 indicates underrepresentation and over 1 indicates overrepresentation. Estimates are derived based on the following number of countries: General and Keyboard Clerks (31 countries), Administration Professionals (31 countries), Business, Administration, Associate Professionals (30 countries), Other Managers (36 countries), Senior Government Officials (39 countries) using the latest available data in the period 2015-2025. Data are mainly from high and upper-middle income countries.

Figure 36: Ratio of women's representation in the judiciary relative to their share of the working age population, by level of court (2025 or latest data available)



Source: UNDP, [Women in the Judiciary Global Dashboard](#)

Note: SDG indicator 16.7.1 is based on the ratio between the share of a specific population group in parliament (a), public service (b), and judiciary (c), and the share of the same group in the population. A value of 1 indicates parity, while a value under 1 indicates underrepresentation and over 1 indicates overrepresentation. Global estimates are based on 117 countries and territories for constitutional/Supreme courts and 96 countries and territories for high-level and 83 countries and territories for low-level courts using the latest available data in the period 2015-2025. The vast majority of data are from high and upper-middle income countries.



DATA TO IMPACT STORY

Using representation data to inform more inclusive public institutions in Armenia

In Armenia, data on women's representation in public administration (SDG indicator 16.7.1b) has helped reveal persistent gaps between women's strong presence in the civil service and their limited access to senior decision-making roles.

Recent data³⁷ showed that women occupied only around 25 per cent of Top Public Management (TPM) positions during 2020-2024, well below the EU Member State average of 41 per cent and the Western Balkans average of 38 per cent. This contrasted with women's representation at lower levels of the civil service, where they accounted for 48 per cent of other managerial positions and 74 per cent of professional positions. The findings highlighted a structural challenge: women were well represented across the public service but remained underrepresented in leadership positions.

Representation data were complemented by evidence on perceived barriers to career progression within the civil service.³⁸ Findings revealed family responsibilities and long working hours as key obstacles affecting women's advancement, particularly into senior management roles. Seventy-two per cent of respondents identified family responsibilities as a major challenge for women compared with 34 per cent for men, and 81 per cent of respondents identified long-working hours as a major barrier for women, compared with 22 per cent for men. Perceived barriers were even more pronounced when it came to leadership positions, with 84 per cent of respondents believing that family responsibilities hinder women's advancement to higher managerial roles because of competing professional and caregiving demands.

KEY NUMBERS

25%

Women in top public management roles

745

Women in professional-level civil service roles

37 OECD/SIGMA *Public Administration in Armenia 2025 Assessment against the Principles of Public Administration Monitoring Report*

38 UNDP Armenia (2020), [public perception survey on gender and inclusive governance in the public service](#).



Using this evidence, public institutions explored practical measures to create more inclusive and supportive working environments. The Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs and the Migration and Citizenship Service partnered with the UNDP Leadership Lift Initiative to develop solutions tailored to workforce needs. As a result, the Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs designed a childcare service aimed at reducing childcare-related pressures on working parents and facilitating a better balance between professional and family responsibilities. The Migration and Citizenship Service designed a multifunctional, family-friendly space that includes a child-friendly area, as well as spaces for mindfulness, rest, and informal interaction, contributing to employee well-being and work-life balance. Through the *Leadership Lift initiative*, mid-career women across these institutions strengthened their leadership and management capacities while also identifying opportunities to address institutional barriers affecting career progression.

Armenia's experience demonstrates how SDG monitoring can move from measurement to action. By combining representation data with evidence on the barriers women face, public institutions were able to identify and implement reforms that support more inclusive workplaces.

DATA TO IMPACT STORY

Turning representation data into institutional change in Bosnia and Herzegovina

In Bosnia and Herzegovina, data on representation in public institutions became a catalyst for institutional reform. Under the leadership of the Agency for Gender Equality of Bosnia and Herzegovina, participating public institutions used the Gender Equality Seal for Public Institutions (SEAL) methodology to move beyond formal compliance and systematically examine who participates in decision-making, who advances within institutions, and who remains excluded.

Participating institutions collected and analysed sex-disaggregated workforce data across leadership structures, recruitment and promotion processes, access to training opportunities, and broader aspects of organizational culture. By assessing workforce composition against national commitments to gender equality, institutions generated evidence on patterns of representation and inclusion within their own systems.

The analysis revealed that, although women were often well represented in the overall public workforce, their representation declined significantly at higher decision-making levels. The data also highlighted institutional practices that unintentionally reinforced inequalities, including barriers within career progression pathways, limited accountability for gender equality commitments, and gaps in gender-responsive human resource management. In some cases, the assessment also revealed limitations in the availability of data on other dimensions of diversity and vulnerability.

Rather than remaining a diagnostic exercise, the evidence informed Gender Equality Seal Improvement Action Plans and guided concrete institutional reforms. Participating institutions strengthened gender-responsive human resource policies, improved recruitment and promotion processes, enhanced accountability mechanisms, reinforced gender focal point functions, and established more systematic approaches to monitoring workforce representation and inclusion.

Advancing women's judicial leadership in Bangladesh

In Bangladesh, data on women's representation in the judiciary under SDG indicator 16.7.1c has helped shift the focus from numerical inclusion to institutional leadership. Drawing on national and regional judicial data and evidence, judicial stakeholders have been able to assess not only the presence of women within the judiciary, but also their progression into senior decision-making roles. The analysis highlighted a persistent "pipeline-to-leadership" challenge: while women are increasingly represented in lower-level courts, they remain significantly underrepresented in senior judicial leadership positions.

The data reveal both progress and continuing disparities. National reporting indicated that 677 of 2,233 lower-level court judges were women, reflecting a growing presence of women at entry and mid-levels of the judiciary. However, women remained underrepresented in the higher judiciary, with only 11 of 118 Supreme Court judges being women in 2025, including a single woman serving in the Appellate Division. Bangladesh has never had a woman Chief Justice.

Building on this, the Supreme Court of Bangladesh convened a Judicial Leadership Colloquium for Women Judges that translated global and regional evidence into a national reform agenda, focusing on leadership, ethics, peer learning, and gender-responsive justice.

Bangladesh's experience demonstrates how representation data can support both measurement and action. By identifying gaps in leadership representation, informing dialogue on institutional barriers, and guiding efforts to strengthen advancement opportunities for women judges, the evidence has become a valuable tool for promoting a more representative, inclusive, and responsive judiciary.

KEY NUMBERS

30.3%

Lower-level court judges who are women

9.3%

Supreme Court judges who are women



SDG INDICATOR 16.B.1 - EXPERIENCE OF DISCRIMINATION

Nearly one in five people worldwide report experiencing discrimination

Discrimination remains a significant barrier to inclusive societies. It continues to affect millions of people worldwide, limiting access to opportunities, services, and participation in public life. Globally, nearly one in five people report having personally experienced discrimination during the previous 12 months.

Women and men self-report similar overall levels of discrimination. However, women are more likely to report discrimination based on gender, reflecting persistent inequalities that often intersect with disability, income, education, and minority status.

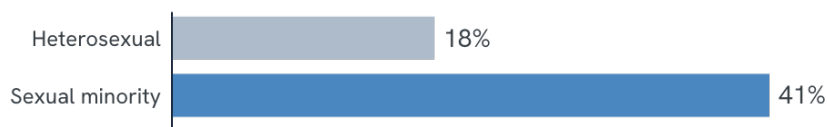
Discrimination is concentrated among already vulnerable groups

The grounds on which people experience discrimination vary across countries, but race, colour, ethnicity, and socio-economic status are among the most frequently reported. Persons with disabilities experience some of the highest levels of discrimination, with nearly one in three reporting discrimination during the previous 12 months. Available evidence also suggests that levels of discrimination are consistently higher among people with lower levels of income and education, while average prevalence of discrimination is slightly higher in Least Developed Countries, suggesting that structural vulnerabilities and development gaps intersect with discriminatory experiences.

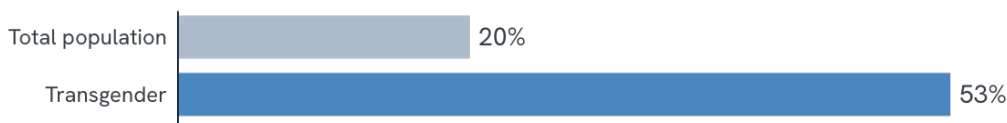
For the first time, newly collected data on sexual orientation and gender identity provide additional insights into forms of exclusion that have historically been difficult to measure. Across countries where such data are available, transgender and gender-diverse individuals frequently report the highest levels of discrimination, often exceeding 60 per cent, while people identifying as sexual minorities report discrimination rates 2.2 times higher than the population average. These findings show that discrimination is not experienced equally across society, and that improved data are making previously invisible forms of discrimination and exclusion increasingly visible.

Figure 37: Percentage of population reporting having been discriminated against (2025 or latest available year)

Sexual orientation



Gender identity



Source: OHCHR

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

The availability of data on discrimination has improved considerably in recent years, enabling more detailed analysis across population groups. However, important gaps remain. Only a handful of countries provide data disaggregated by income, education, or migration status, and only a limited number collect information on sexual orientation and gender identity. Repeated surveys are also relatively uncommon, limiting the ability to monitor changes over time. As a result, some of the most severe forms of exclusion remain insufficiently documented, particularly where measurement capacity is weakest. Continued investment in inclusive and disaggregated data collection is therefore essential to better understand who is most affected by discrimination and to ensure that no one is left behind.



Using data to strengthen institutional responses to discrimination in Mexico

Mexico demonstrates how regular data collection on people's experiences of discrimination (SDG indicator 16.b.1) can help identify inequalities that might otherwise remain hidden and provide evidence for more targeted policy and legislative responses.

Mexico collects data for the indicator through the National Survey on Discrimination (ENADIS³⁹), implemented periodically by the National Institute of Statistics and Geography (INEGI), in collaboration with the National Council to Prevent Discrimination (CONAPRED) and the National Commission for Human Rights (CNDH). The survey captures people's self-reported experiences of discrimination across multiple grounds, including sex, age, disability, ethnicity, migration status, sexual orientation, and socioeconomic status, among others.

Results from successive survey rounds have shown that discrimination remains widespread, with particularly high prevalence among Indigenous people, persons with disabilities, and women. Importantly, the data revealed two critical insights for policymakers. First, discrimination was not limited to interactions between individuals. Experiences of discrimination were frequently reported in interactions with public authorities, including police, health services, and administrative offices. Second, while legal protections existed, awareness of complaint mechanisms and trust in institutions responsible for addressing discrimination were low, especially among marginalized groups. By documenting these experiences systematically, ENADIS provided evidence on where formal legal protections may not yet translate into equal treatment in practice.

In response, the data was explicitly used to advocate for reforms to Mexico's anti-discrimination framework, including through the development of the National Human Rights Observatory. For example, by revealing where discrimination is most prevalent, SDG indicator 16.b.1 data helped guide the development of targeted training programmes for public officials delivered by bodies such as CONAPRED, to strengthen capacity on equality and non-discrimination.

39 Instituto Nacional de Estadística y Geografía (National Institute of Statistics and Geography, INEGI) (2022), [Encuesta Nacional sobre Discriminación \(National Survey on Discrimination, ENADIS\)](#).

SDG INDICATOR 16.6.1- GOVERNMENT EXPENDITURES

Governments are improving their ability to deliver approved budgets

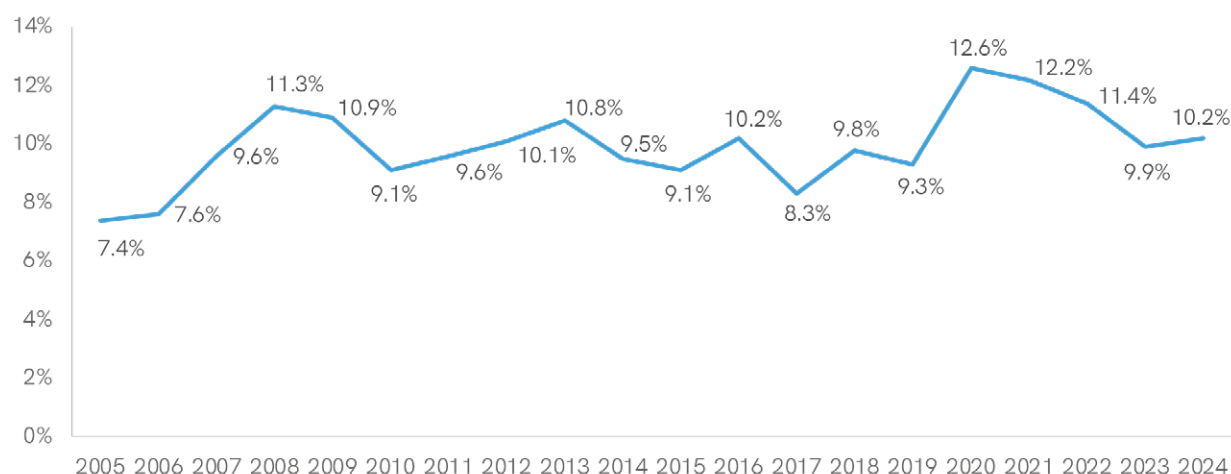
Public budgets translate government priorities into investments in public services, infrastructure, and social protection. The extent to which governments implement approved budgets as planned provides an important measure of institutional effectiveness, accountability, and the capacity to deliver on policy commitments.

Following the disruptions caused by the COVID-19 pandemic, governments have made steady progress in improving budget reliability and expenditure forecasting. The global



average absolute deviation between approved and actual government expenditure, which captures both overspending and underspending relative to the approved budget, declined from 12.6 per cent in 2020 to 10.2 per cent in 2024. This suggests that governments are becoming more effective at aligning actual spending with approved budgets and strengthening public financial management.

Figure 38: Global Average Absolute Deviation Between Approved and Actual Government Expenditure



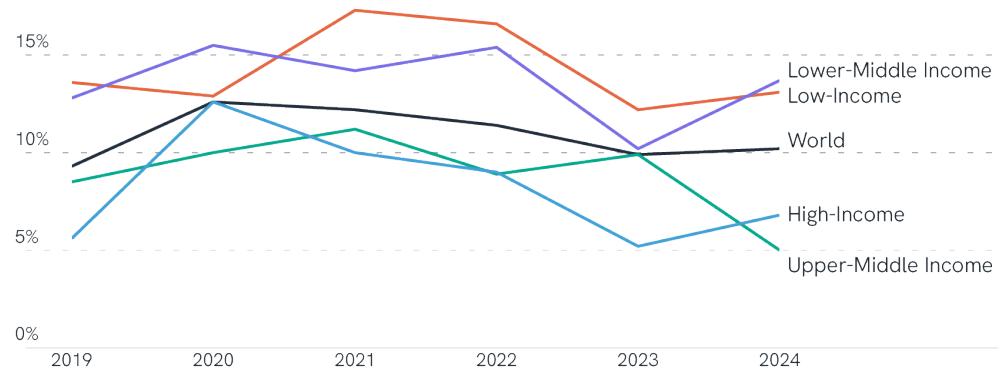
Source: PEFA

Note: Absolute deviation measures the percentage difference between approved and actual government expenditure, regardless of whether actual spending is higher or lower than planned.

Budget reliability remains weaker in lower-income countries

Despite overall progress, important differences persist across income groups. Between 2021 and 2024, low-income countries recorded the largest budget deviations between approved and actual expenditure, with median deviations of around 11.8 per cent. By contrast, most high-income and upper-middle-income countries generally maintained deviations below 7 per cent. These differences suggest that stronger public financial management systems and institutional capacity are associated with more reliable budget execution.

Figure 39: Average Absolute Deviation Between Approved and Actual Government Expenditure, by Income group (2019-2024)



Source: PEFA

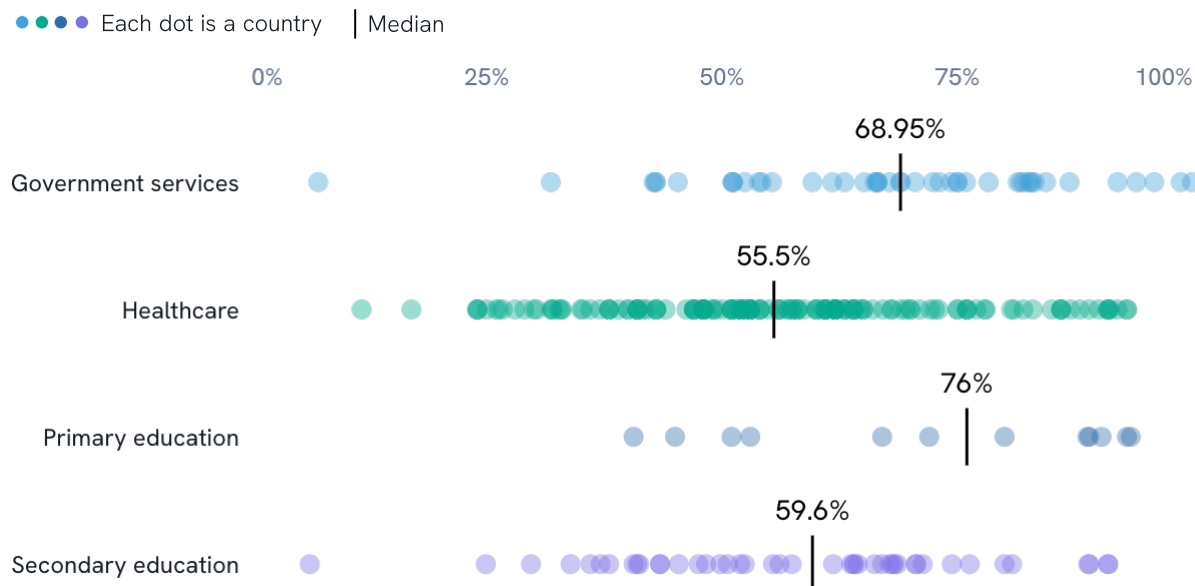
Note: Absolute deviation measures the percentage difference between approved and actual government expenditure, regardless of whether actual spending is higher or lower than planned.

Quality public services remain out of reach for many people

Implementing approved budgets is only one part of effective governance. Ultimately, effective governance is reflected in whether people can access high-quality public services and whether those services meet their needs. In a world facing multiple pressures, including fiscal constraints, demographic change and rapid technological transformation, governments are under increasing pressure to deliver accessible, reliable and high-quality services.

Across healthcare, education, and government services⁴⁰, the quality of public services has become a defining feature of how individuals experience and interact with their governments. While important data gaps remain, available evidence points to a substantial difference in satisfaction with public services across countries. Among countries with available data, satisfaction ranges from less than 10 per cent in some countries to over 90 per cent in others. These wide gaps suggest that access to quality public services remains highly uneven and that many people continue to face barriers to services that are essential for well-being and inclusion.

Figure 40: Distribution of satisfaction with public services across countries for quality of healthcare services, primary education services, secondary education services, government services (2025 or latest year available)



Source: UNDP, Gallup World Poll

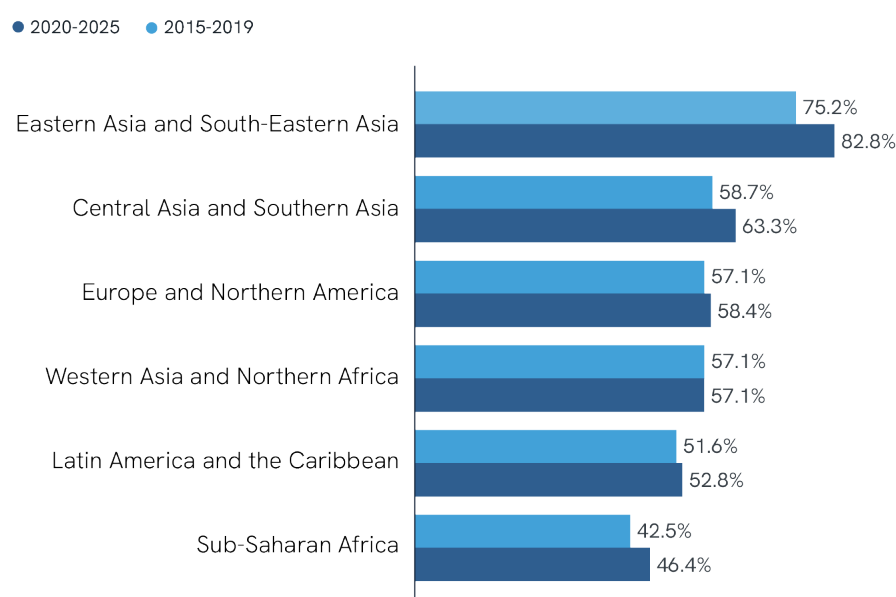
Note: Estimates are based on the latest available survey data between 2015 and 2025 for 148 countries (health services), 12 countries (primary education services), 44 countries (secondary education services) and 46 countries (government services). Education and government services are primarily based on data from high and middle-income countries. The line within each box indicates the median level of satisfaction, the X indicates the average, while the box shows the values for the middle 50 per cent of countries. Whiskers extend to the lowest and highest values observed with circles showing outliers. The spread of each boxplot highlights the extent of variation across countries, with wider ranges reflecting more uneven service delivery outcomes.

⁴⁰ These include services to obtain government-issued identification documents such as national identity cards, passports, driver's licenses and voter's cards, and services for the civil registration of life events such as births, marriages and deaths.



Healthcare provides the most comprehensive basis for global trend analysis, with trend data available for a subset of 95 countries. Satisfaction with the accessibility of healthcare has improved modestly over the past decade, but regional disparities remain pronounced. Countries in Eastern and South-Eastern Asia report the highest average satisfaction (88.2 per cent), while Sub-Saharan Africa records the lowest (46.4 per cent). These persistent differences show that, while progress has been made, access to quality public services remains highly unequal across countries.

Figure 41: Proportion of the population who say that they are satisfied with the availability of quality healthcare, (2015 and 2025 or latest year available)



Source: UNDP, Gallup World Poll

Note: Estimates are based on the earliest available year of survey data between 2015 and 2019 and latest available year of survey data between 2020 and 2025 for 95 countries (health services). Regional estimates are based on the following number of countries respectively: Europe and Northern America (18), Latin America and the Caribbean (11), Eastern and South-Eastern Asia (9), Sub-Saharan Africa (31), Northern Africa and Western Asia (15), Central and Southern Asia (11). Gallup World Poll asks the question: "In the city or area where you live, are you satisfied or dissatisfied with the availability of quality healthcare?"

DATA CONSIDERATIONS

Comparable data on people's experiences and satisfaction with public services remain uneven across sectors. While information on satisfaction with the availability of quality healthcare is available for 148 countries, comparable data exist for only 12 countries on primary education, 44 on secondary education, and 46 on government services. Expanding comparable survey data across a broader range of public services will be essential to better understand how people experience government performance and to identify where improvements in service delivery are most needed.

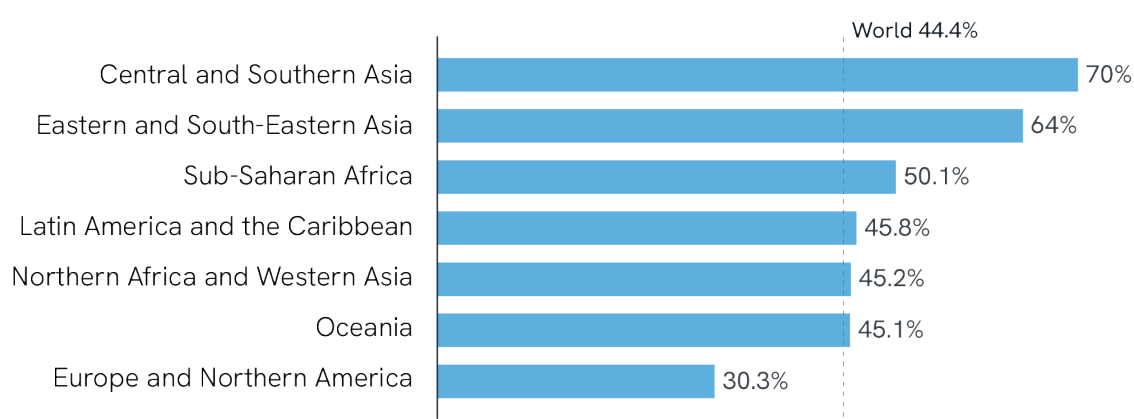
Fewer than half of people feel they have a say in government decisions

Inclusive governance is not only about who institutions represent or the services they deliver. It is also about whether people feel they have a say in public decision-making and whether political systems allow them to have an influence on politics.⁴¹ Globally, less than half of people believe they have a say in what their government does, revealing a persistent gap between participation in public life and people's perception of inclusion in decision-making.

Some of the lowest levels are found in Europe and Northern America, where only around one in three people believe they have a say in government decisions. Across regions, these perceptions differ by as much as 40 percentage points, demonstrating that inclusive decision-making remains an important challenge in many countries across the world.

Women are less likely than men to feel that they have a say in government decisions. Across 37 high-income countries with sex-disaggregated data, 27.3 per cent of women believe they have a say in what their government does, compared with 32.6 per cent of men. These findings suggest that perceptions of political inclusion and responsiveness continue to be shaped by gender inequalities and social norms, even in countries where opportunities for participation and representation are relatively better developed.

Figure 42: Proportion of the population who believe decision-making is inclusive, by region (2025 or latest year available)



Source: UNDP

Note: The question asked is: "How much would you say the political system in your country allows people like you to have a say in what the government does?". These estimates are derived from data covering 83 countries, using the latest available information from 2015 to 2025.

⁴¹ The extent to which people feel they have a say in what their government does and influence politics is known as "external political efficacy" and reflects perceptions of how inclusive and responsive the political system is to people's views and demands. This concept is used to measure beliefs regarding system's responsiveness to people's demands. Internal political efficacy instead refers to confidence of the individual in his or her own abilities to understand politics and to act politically.

Figure 43: Proportion of the population who believe decision-making is inclusive, by sex (2025 or latest year available).



Source: UNDP

Note: 37 high-income countries with available sex-disaggregated data. The question asked is: "How much would you say the political system in your country allows people like you to have a say in what the government does?". These estimates are derived from data covering a total of 37 high-income countries using the latest available information from 2015 to 2025.

SDG INDICATOR 16.10.2 – ACCESS TO INFORMATION

Legal guarantees for access to information are widespread, but implementation remains uneven

Access to information is a cornerstone of transparent, accountable, and inclusive governance. It enables people to understand how public decisions are made, scrutinize government action, and participate more effectively in public life. As of 2026, 141 UN Member States have adopted statutory guarantees for public access to information, compared with just 14 countries in 1990, reflecting a remarkable increase in fulfilling the right to information. The most recent adopters include Senegal and Cuba, adopting access to information laws in 2025 and in 2026, respectively. Regionally, this includes 51 countries in Europe and Northern America, 27 in Latin America and the Caribbean, 27 in Asia and the Pacific, 27 in Africa, and 9 in the Arab States.⁴²

Legal guarantees, however, do not always translate into effective access in practice. In 2025, 49 out of 123 countries responding to the UNESCO annual survey⁴³ reported almost 5.9 million access to information (ATI) requests, demonstrating the growing use of these laws. At the same time, findings also show that many countries continue to face challenges in implementing access to information legislation, including the absence of record-keeping systems, limited enforcement of ATI laws, lack of designated ATI bodies or institutional roles, insufficient data on legally mandated record keeping, and the absence of independent oversight authorities.

These implementation gaps are also reflected in the first large-scale global assessment of how access to information laws function in practice.⁴⁴ Identical ATI requests submitted across 76 countries found that 38 per cent of requests received no substantive response ("mute refusals"), effectively leaving the

⁴² [The Sustainable Development Goals Extended Report 2026, Goal 16](#). No regional aggregates aligned with the SDG Regional Groupings were published.

⁴³ [UNESCO \(n.d.\) UNESCO Survey on Public Access to Information \(SDG Indicator 16.10.2\)](#)

⁴⁴ Mendel, T. and Vagliano, R. (2025) [Global Comparative Testing of Responses to Requests for Information](#). Halifax, NS: Centre for Law and Democracy.

right to information existing only on paper. Although 54 per cent of requests resulted in some information being provided, only 42 per cent received full disclosure. These findings demonstrate that, while legal recognition of the right to information has become widespread, ensuring that this right can be effectively exercised remains a significant challenge.



Figure 44: Countries with constitutional, statutory and/or policy guarantees for access to information (2025)



Source: [SDG Global Database](#)

SDG INDICATOR 16.8.1 – REPRESENTATION OF DEVELOPING COUNTRIES IN INTERNATIONAL ORGANIZATIONS

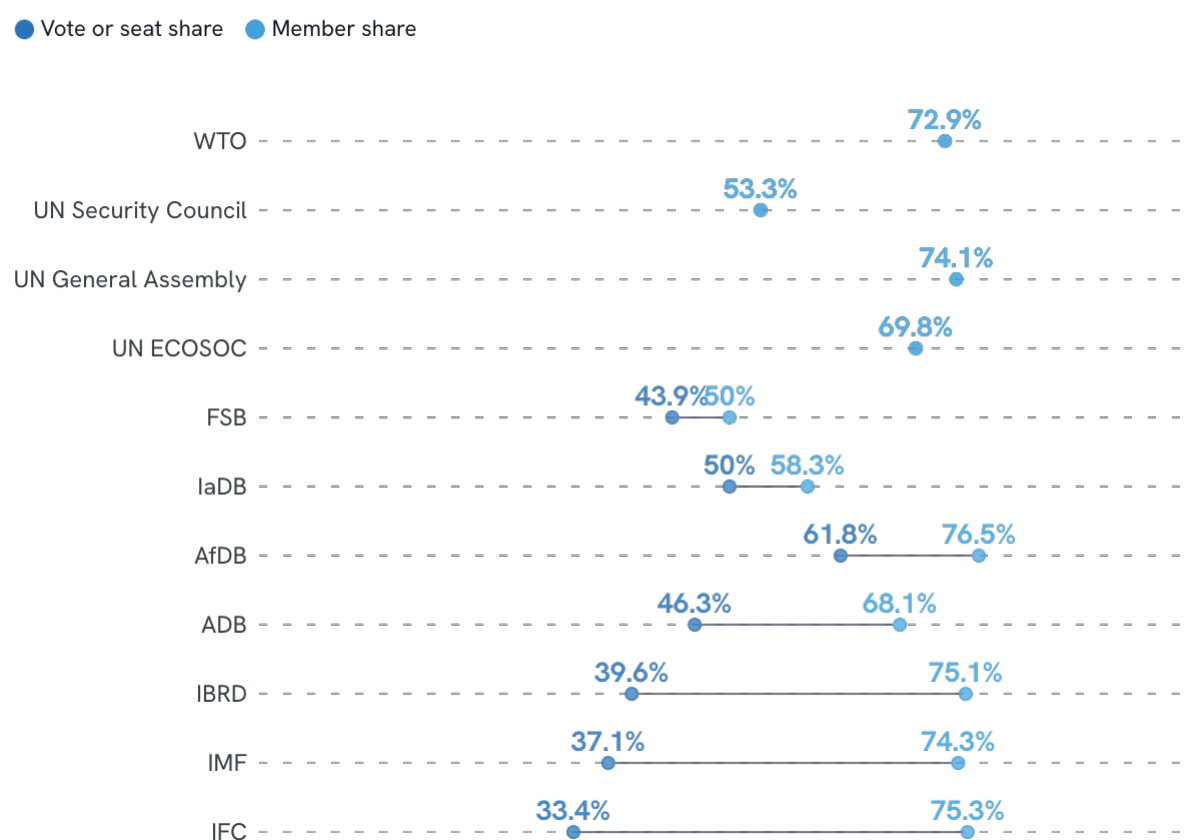
Global economic governance has not kept pace with a changing world

Goal 16 extends beyond national institutions. Inclusive and effective global governance also depends on whether international institutions reflect the voices and interests of all countries. Accordingly, Goal 16 includes an indicator that measures the representation and voting rights of developing countries in major international organizations, recognising that more inclusive global governance is essential for addressing shared development challenges.

Despite repeated commitments to strengthen the participation of developing countries in international decision-making, progress has been limited. While complementary reforms have expanded their participation in some international economic and financial institutions, meaningful changes to voting rights have remained largely out of reach. As a result, the balance of representation in international financial institutions, regional development banks, and standard-setting bodies has remained largely unchanged in recent years.

The largest developed economies continue to collectively hold veto powers in the decision-making bodies of some of these institutions, and reforms to voting rights remain among the most contested issues in global governance. Today, developing countries hold 37 per cent of the voting rights in the International Monetary Fund and 39 per cent in the World Bank, despite accounting for 75 per cent of the membership of both institutions. Recent reviews of voting rights at both organizations concluded without agreement on further realignment, highlighting the growing difficulty of reforming global governance in an increasingly fragmented geopolitical environment.

Figure 45: Vote shares of developing countries in some of the main international financial and economic institutions



Source: UN DESA



The role of institutions in building inclusive societies

Institutions play a crucial role in ensuring that all people are recognized, represented, and able to participate meaningfully in public life. The evidence presented across these indicators highlights the many ways in which institutions shape inclusion, equal participation, and equitable access to opportunities and services. Whether people feel included depends heavily on the ability of institutions to recognize individuals, protect their rights, and respond to their needs.

Inclusive institutions ensure that every person is legally recognized through a legal identity, protected from discrimination, represented in public decision-making, able to access information and public services on equal terms, and empowered to participate in decisions that shape their lives. They also ensure that governments respond fairly and effectively to the needs of all people by delivering quality public services that are accessible, responsive, and equitable, regardless of gender, age, disability, ethnicity, income or other characteristics. In doing so, inclusive institutions strengthen the relationship between people and the state by demonstrating that public institutions serve everyone fairly rather than a privileged few.

The indicators presented in this chapter illustrate both areas of progress and persistent gaps in achieving these objectives. They show the extent to which people are legally recognized, represented in public institutions, protected from discrimination, and able to access public services and information. Together, they provide a picture of how effectively institutions promote inclusion and support meaningful participation in society.

When institutions function effectively, they help reduce barriers, expand opportunities, and strengthen social cohesion. When institutions fail to share power equitably, exclusion deepens, discrimination persists, public services become less responsive, and decisions become less representative of the societies they serve. Trust in public institutions erodes as people lose confidence that they are recognized, treated equally, and able to influence public decisions. Building inclusive societies therefore requires institutions that not only serve people, but also ensure that everyone has a place, a voice and an equal opportunity to participate in shaping their future.



Measuring SDG 16 progress: Remaining challenges

The background of the slide features a dark blue gradient. In the lower half, there are several overlapping, wavy, organic shapes in varying shades of dark blue and navy, creating a sense of depth and movement. The text is positioned in the upper left quadrant, rendered in a clean, white, serif typeface.

When the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development was adopted in 2015, many of the issues covered by Goal 16 were not yet routinely measured through official statistics. Areas such as conflict-related deaths, violence against children, discrimination and violence against human rights defenders, illicit financial and arms flows, representation in public institutions and the judiciary, and inclusive decision-making were all recognized as important for sustainable development, but internationally agreed statistical standards and methodologies for measuring these concepts were often lacking. As a result, significant methodological development and capacity-building efforts were needed to enable countries to produce comparable and reliable data.

This challenge was reflected in the initial classification of the SDG indicator framework. In 2016, 8 of the 23 indicators under Goal 16 were classified as Tier III,⁴⁵ meaning that no internationally established methodology or standards were available to support regular data production and international comparability. The expansion of the framework also brought new measurement challenges. In 2020, indicator 16.3.3 was added to the global indicator framework, and at the time of its adoption, an internationally agreed methodology had not yet been established.

A decade later, the monitoring landscape of Goal 16 has changed significantly. Custodian agencies, in close

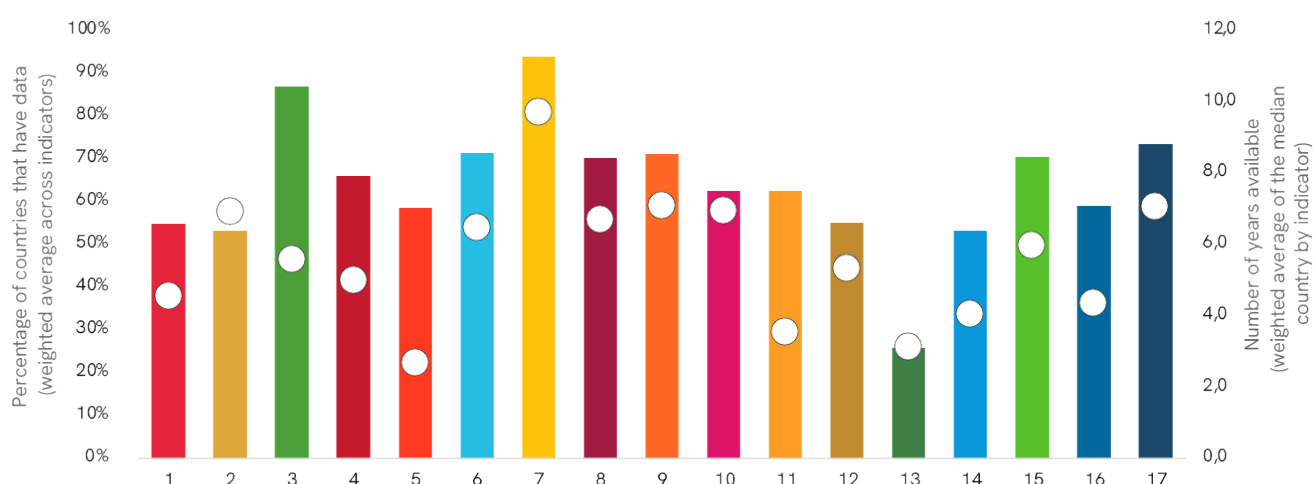
collaboration with national statistical offices and other national institutions, have developed methodologies, survey tools, administrative data standards and reporting mechanisms. At the same time, countries have also expanded their capacities to collect and report data across a range of areas related to peace, justice, governance, human rights and inclusion.

These collective efforts and investments have translated into substantial improvements in data availability. In the 2026 reporting cycle, 58.9 per cent of countries had reported data for at least one indicator under each SDG 16 target since 2015, up from 40 per cent in 2023 and 22.4 per cent in 2019.

Despite these gains, important data gaps remain. While methodologies are now available for all SDG 16 indicators, many countries do not produce SDG 16 data regularly enough to monitor change over time. Coverage also remains uneven across indicators, particularly for those that rely on specialized surveys or coordination across multiple institutions. As 2030 approaches, the priority is therefore no longer simply to measure Goal 16, but to institutionalize its measurement within national statistical systems and governance processes. Strengthening the regular production, use and dissemination of SDG 16 data will be essential not only for monitoring global progress, but also for informing evidence-based policies that advance peaceful, just and inclusive societies.

⁴⁵ Indicators which were classified as Tier III were: 16.1.2, 16.2.1, 16.3.3, 16.4.1, 16.4.2, 16.6.2, 16.7.1b, 16.7.1c, 16.7.2, 16.10.1, and 16.b.1.

Figure 46: Percentage of countries that have reported data on the SDG Indicators, June 2026 (left) and number of years available (right) (June 2026)



Source: [SDG Global Database](#)

Note: Weighted average of the median country by indicator

Progress in data availability, but major gaps remain

The data used to monitor the SDG 16 indicators are drawn from a combination of administrative records and household surveys, each of which plays a distinct role in capturing different dimensions of peace, justice and inclusive institutions.

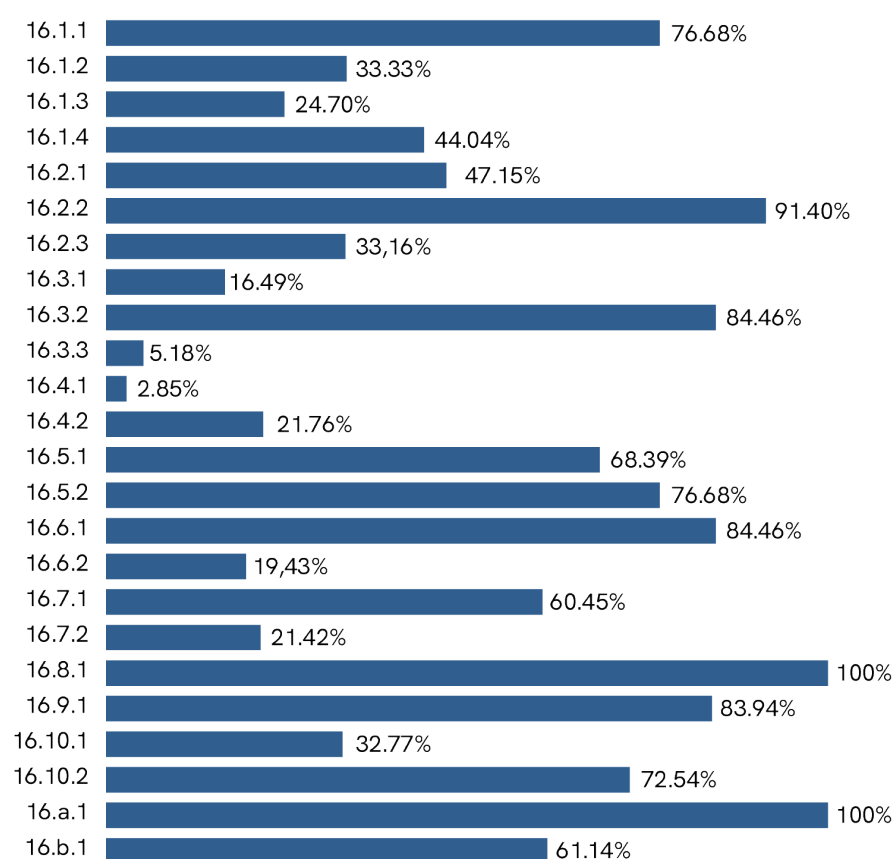
Administrative data can provide regular, timely and cost-effective information and are essential for monitoring many SDG16 indicators. Over the past decade, many countries have strengthened administrative systems and improved reporting mechanisms, contributing to substantial gains in data availability. However, challenges remain. Data are often spread across multiple institutions with different mandates and information systems, while variations in definitions, recording practices and data-sharing arrangements can limit comparability and use. In addition, administrative records capture only those individuals and events that come into contact with public institutions. This is a particularly important limitation for areas such as violence, corruption and access to justice, where many incidents remain unreported. Furthermore, administrative data can show who uses public services and institutions, but they often provide limited insight into people's experiences, perceptions and levels of satisfaction.

Household surveys complement administrative records by capturing experiences and perceptions that are not reflected in official systems. They make it possible to understand experiences of violence and discrimination, bribery, perceptions of safety and trust, satisfaction with public services and whether people feel they have a say in government decision-making. However, nationally representative surveys require substantial financial resources and are often conducted infrequently.

Recognizing the important challenges around household surveys, the SDG 16 Survey Initiative, jointly developed by UNDP, UNODC and OHCHR, was designed to support countries in collecting comparable survey data across multiple SDG 16 indicators through a single integrated survey instrument. By reducing the need for separate data collection exercises, the initiative helps lower costs, improve international comparability and support the regular production of data on governance, justice, security and human rights.

Despite considerable progress over the past decade, data availability continues to vary significantly across SDG 16 indicators. While some indicators now have near-global coverage, others remain available for only a limited number of countries. Closing these gaps will require sustained investment in national statistical capacity, stronger institutional coordination, continued implementation of internationally agreed methodologies, and greater integration of SDG 16 indicators into national statistical programmes.

Figure 47: Countries with Goal 16 data for at least one year since 2015, by indicator (average across countries in percent)



Source: [SDG Global Database](#)

Note: SDG indicator 16.1.2 is only applicable to the subset of territories where internationally recognized armed conflicts exist. While data for 20 conflicts have been included at the time of this publication, this is not reflected in all the six series under the indicator. Due to the focus on civilian deaths, the series covering non-civilians and persons of unknown status only include a few conflicts. In addition, one of the series includes only global aggregates.

Better coverage does not yet mean more inclusive data

Improvements in overall data availability have not been matched by equivalent progress in data disaggregation. The commitment to leave no one behind requires data that make it possible to identify disparities not only between countries, but also among population groups within countries.

The global indicator framework specifies different disaggregation requirements depending on the indicator and the policy issue being measured. Understanding which disaggregated data are currently available and reported for global monitoring is therefore important for assessing how well existing data can be used to identify inequalities and monitor inclusion.

As shown in Table 1, sex and age are the most commonly reported forms of disaggregation across SDG 16 indicators in the Global SDG Database. By contrast, data disaggregated by disability status, migratory status, and population groups remain far less common.⁴⁶

There are encouraging examples of progress. Several SDG 16 indicators, particularly those on discrimination, public service satisfaction and representation in public institutions increasingly support more detailed disaggregation are beginning to provide greater insight into inequalities within countries. Nevertheless, significant gaps remain. Strengthening the availability and reporting of disaggregated data on a regular basis, in line with internationally agreed standards and principles of self-identification, privacy and statistical confidentiality, will be essential for ensuring that SDG 16 monitoring captures not only overall progress but also who is being left behind. As countries continue to institutionalize SDG 16 measurement, expanding the coverage and use of disaggregated data will be critical for informing more inclusive policies and decision-making.

Table 1: Number of countries with reporting at least one year, and with disaggregated data (2015 – 2025)

Indicator	Countries/ Territories Reporting Data	Sex	Age	Disability	Population Group	Location	Education	Income
16.1.1	171	146	0	0	0	0	0	0
16.1.2	20	20	20	0	0	0	0	0
16.1.3	94	87	0	0	0	0	0	0
16.1.4	91	81	0	0	0*	0	0	0
16.10.1	141	0	0	0	0	0	0	0

⁴⁶ It is also important to note that the limited availability of disaggregated data in Global SDG Database does not necessarily mean that countries do not produce such information. In some areas, countries report and publish more detailed disaggregated data nationally than are currently disseminated through global SDG reporting mechanisms. For example, age-disaggregated homicide data are available from many countries and are published through UNODC database, but these data are not systematically transmitted to the Global SDG Database. Similarly for SDG indicator 16.9.1 where countries do produce sex-disaggregated data but that is not disseminated via the SDG Global Database.

Indicator	Countries/ Territories Reporting Data	Sex	Age	Disability	Population Group	Location	Education	Income
16.2.1	93	0		0	0	0	0	0
16.2.2	175	158		0	0	0	0	0
16.2.3	66	66			0	0	0	0
16.3.1	77	65	0	0	0	0	0	0
16.3.2	189	117	0	0	0	0	0	0
16.3.3	11	8	0	1	0	2	0	0
16.5.1	139	13	0	0	0	0	0	0
16.6.2	151	147	11	4	5	9	0	2
16.7.1a	193**	193	193	0	0	0	0	0
16.7.1b	157	157	41**	11	6	0	0	0
16.7.1c	131	131	44**	5	5	0	0	0
16.7.2	84	46	8	2	5	7	6	0
16.9.1	166	0	166**	0	0	0	0	0
16.b.1	122	99	17	47	0	66	10	9

Legend

	Recommended and reported
	Recommended but not reported
	Reported though not recommended
	Not recommended, not reported

* Metadata recommends reporting on ethnicity/migration background, used as proxy for Population Group.

** Indicator implicitly reports by sex or age (not separately recommended), but as a prerequisite for the value.

Source: [SDG Global Database](#)

Note: The table reports the number of countries and territories providing at least one observation with each type of disaggregation for each SDG 16 indicator, based on data available in the Global SDG database. Countries are counted only once per indicator, regardless of the number of years for which data are reported. It is important to note that the absence of disaggregated data in the Global SDG Database does not necessarily imply that such data do not exist. For some indicators, counts are calculated by aggregating multiple series into a single measure. This approach is used where different series capture different components of the same indicator. Examples include indicators 16.10.1, 16.1.3, 16.3.1, and 16.6.2. A country is counted as reporting disaggregated data on that indicator if any of its underlying series includes the relevant disaggregation. Indicators 16.4.1, 16.4.2, 16.5.2, 16.6.1, 16.8.1, 16.10.2, 16.a.1 were excluded as they are aggregated across financial, administrative or institutional measures, and therefore not applicable to demographic disaggregation.



The role of institutions in SDG 16 monitoring

One of the most important achievements of the past decade has been demonstrating that complex dimensions of peace, justice, governance, human rights and inclusion can be measured through official statistics. Through sustained collaboration between custodian agencies, national statistical offices and other national institutions, methodological standards, survey instruments, implementation guidance and reporting mechanisms have been developed for all SDG 16 indicators. These efforts have helped transform areas once considered difficult to measure into areas that can increasingly be monitored in a systematic and internationally comparable manner.

The next challenge is sustainability. Regular production of SDG 16 data requires predictable financing, skilled personnel, digital infrastructure, and continued technical support. It also requires embedding SDG 16 indicators within routine data collection systems, including both household surveys and administrative records, so that data are produced consistently over time rather than through one-off reporting exercises.

Producing SDG 16 data is an inherently institutional undertaking. Unlike indicators that can be produced from a single statistical source, SDG 16 monitoring often relies on information generated by ministries of justice, police services, courts, prison administrations, electoral management bodies, national human rights institutions and other public authorities, in

addition to national statistical offices. Producing coherent and comparable statistics therefore requires effective coordination, clear institutional mandates, common standards and robust mechanisms for data sharing and use across government.

National statistical offices play a central role in this process. As coordinators of national statistical systems, they help ensure the quality, consistency and comparability of data produced by different institutions and support the integration of SDG 16 indicators into national statistical programmes. Their coordinating role is particularly important given the cross-cutting nature of Goal 16 and the wide range of administrative and survey-based sources on which it depends.

Strengthening SDG 16 monitoring therefore requires investment in national statistical systems as a whole, rather than in individual indicators alone. Building sustainable capacity across data-producing institutions, strengthening partnerships between producers and users of data, and institutionalizing data-sharing arrangements will be essential for maintaining the progress achieved over the past decade. As 2030 approaches, ensuring that SDG 16 data are produced regularly, used in policymaking and embedded within national statistical systems will be critical for sustaining measurement of peace, justice and inclusive governance beyond 2030.

Technical note

The findings and analysis in this report are based on the latest data submitted and/or validated by Member States and collated by the custodian agencies for the annual reporting on the progress for goal 16 worldwide and by various country groups. The country groupings are based on the geographic regions defined under the Standard Country or Area Codes for Statistical Use (known as M49)⁴⁷ of the United Nations Statistics Division and uses the short form name as per the United Nations Terminology Database. Due to limited data availability for some of the indicators or for the purpose of presentation, some of the M49 regions have been combined. Although there is no established convention for the designation of “developed” and “developing” countries or areas in the United Nations system, data for some indicators in this report are still being presented for developed and developing regions and countries for the purpose of statistical analysis only, and are based on the practice employed by the international agencies that provided the data.

A complete list of countries included in each region and subregion and country group is available at unstats.un.org/sdgs/indicators/regional-groups.

The term “country” as used in the text of this publication also refers, as appropriate, to territories and areas. The designations employed and the presentation of the material in this publication do not imply the expression of any opinion whatsoever on the part of the United Nations concerning the legal status of any country, territory, city or area or of its authorities, or concerning the delimitation of its frontiers or boundaries. The terms “country” and “Member State” have been used interchangeably.

In this publication, the term “children” is used to refer to different age groups depending on the context of specific indicators. For indicator 16.1.2 – “Conflict-related deaths per 100,000 population, by sex, age and cause” and indicator 16.2.2 – “Number of victims of human trafficking per 100,000 population, by sex, age and form of exploitation”, children are defined as those under 18 years old.

For indicator 16.2.1 – “Proportion of children aged 1–17 years who experienced any physical punishment and/or psychological aggression by caregivers in the past month”, the available data pertains to children aged 1 to 14 years old. Finally, for indicator 16.9.1 – “Proportion of children under 5 years of age whose births have been registered with a civil authority, by age”, the term refers to children under 5 years old.

⁴⁷ Full details of the M49 standard can be found on the Statistics Division website at <https://unstats.un.org/unsd/methodology/m49>

With contributions from:

